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Paddy procurement delay sparks protest in Gharaunda

Farmers lock market panel office gate, allege distress sales below MSP

PARVEEN ARORA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

KARNAL, OCTOBER 4
Angry over alleged delays in paddy procurement at the Gharaunda grain market, scores of farmers on Sunday locked the main gate of the market committee office and burnt an effigy of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini.

The protest was organised under the banner of the Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Morcha and led by BKU (Sir Chhotu Ram) spokesperson Bahadur Singh Mehla and state committee member Jagdeep Singh Aulakh.

The farmers alleged that large quantities of harvested paddy were lying in the grain market as procurement had not picked up despite the government announcing that it would begin on September 29. They also cited crop verification on the Meri Fasal Mera Byora (MFMB) portal and non-issuance of gate passes as hurdles. Mehla said the government had promised that every grain of paddy would be procured, but the situation on the ground was different. “The Chief Minister is



BKU (Sir Chhotu Ram) farmers burn an effigy of CM Nayab Singh Saini at the Gharaunda committee office.

going to Punjab and claiming that his government is purchasing every single grain. He should come to Gharaunda and see the reality. Farmers have brought their paddy to the grain markets, but it is not being procured,” he said.

He claimed that paddy with moisture content below the permissible 17% was lying in the market and alleged that delays in portal verification were further slowing down procurement. Aulakh blamed the

absence of rice millers for the bottleneck, saying farmers should not be made to suffer because of a dispute between the government and millers.

“If there is any problem with the rice mills, the government and administration should resolve it. Why should the farmer pay the price?” he said.

Aulakh alleged that some farmers had already been forced to sell their produce at Rs 200-300 per quintal below the minimum sup-

port price (MSP) because of the delays.

He warned that farmers could intensify their agitation if procurement was not expedited. “We do not want to block the highway, but if the government continues to ignore us, we will have no other option,” he said.

The protesters demanded immediate procurement and issuance of gate passes, besides expediting crop verification so that farmers were not forced into distress sales.

STF team attacked in Gurugram, cop critically injured

SANJAY YADAV

GURUGRAM, OCTOBER 4
A constable of the Special Task Force (STF) was critically injured after a group of men allegedly attacked an STF team on Jail Road near Naya-gaon village in the Bhondsi area last night.

The injured constable, Amit Kumar, sustained injuries to his leg and spine and is undergoing treatment at a hospital. Following a complaint by the STF, an FIR has been registered at the Bhondsi police station under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The police have launched raids to nab the accused, who are absconding.

According to sources, the STF team was travelling in a government vehicle towards its headquarters in Bhondsi when it came across a clash between two groups travelling in separate vehicles on Jail Road. While one group fled the spot, members of the other group allegedly attacked the STF vehicle when it reached the spot. The attackers allegedly opened fire at the STF team during the assault. Amit Kumar was injured when one of the vehicles allegedly rammed the door of the STF vehicle. He subsequently fell onto the road, following which the tyre of a Scorpio reportedly ran over his leg.

The attackers then fled the spot in their vehicles.

Wanted miscreant injured in Sonepat encounter, arrested

MUKESH TANDON
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

SONEPAT, OCTOBER 4
A wanted miscreant, allegedly involved in the firing on Haryana singer Diler Kharkiya's SUV, was injured in both legs during an encounter with a joint team of the STF, Sonepat, and the Delhi Police Crime Branch in the Barota-Chhatehra area of Sonepat district late on Saturday night.

The accused, identified as Rohit, alias Budha, of Ladpur village in the Rai area, was admitted to the Civil Hospital, Sonepat. A motorcycle and a pistol were recovered from the spot.

Inspector Ajay Dhankar of the STF, Sonepat, said the accused was wanted in several criminal cases, including loot, attempt to murder and murder. His name had also surfaced during the investigation into the firing on singer Diler Kharkiya's SUV in Kharak Kalan village of Bhiwani district. The firing incident was reported on the night of September 17 when a motorcycle-borne youth allegedly fired at the singer's vehicle and fled. CCTV footage of the incident later surfaced on social media. A person using the name Anil Pandit had also claimed responsibility for the firing through a social media post.

“Rohit's name came to the

Accused linked to firing on singer Diler's SUV



The accused, Rohit, receives medical treatment at a hospital.

JOINT OPERATION YIELDS RESULT

■ Acting on a tip-off about Rohit's whereabouts, the STF Sonepat and Delhi Police Crime Branch teams launched a joint operation in the Barota-Chhatehra area.

■ According to the police, Rohit opened fire at the teams after spotting them. The police retaliated, during which he sustained bullet injuries in both legs.

fore during the investigation into the firing incident, following which the police began searching for him,” said Inspector Dhankar.

Acting on a tip-off about his whereabouts, the STF Sonepat and Delhi Police Crime Branch teams launched a joint operation in the Barota-Chhatehra area on Saturday night.

According to the police, Rohit opened fire at the teams after spotting them. The police retaliated, during which he sustained bullet

injuries in both legs and was subsequently apprehended.

Inspector Dhankar said Rohit was also wanted in connection with the murder of toll plaza manager Sanjay Shukla, who was killed at the Bad-do-Patti toll plaza on the Hisar-Chandigarh highway near Barwala in Hisar district on June 23. Sources said the accused was reportedly associated with the Lawrence Bishnoi gang. The police are verifying his criminal record and further investigation is under way.



Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini at the Sunteck Convention and Exhibition Centre in Singapore on Sunday.

Saini woos Singapore Inc to invest in state

CHANDIGARH, OCTOBER 4

Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday invited Singapore businesses to explore investment opportunities in the state, highlighting its investor-friendly policies, industrial potential, infrastructure and facilities available to investors.

Saini was speaking at a programme organised by the Singapore Business Federation (SBF) during his visit to Singapore. Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai and Ambassador of India to Singapore Shilpak Ambule were also present.

The meeting brought together industrialists and business representatives from Singapore to discuss ways to strengthen economic ties between India and Singapore and expand opportunities for trade and investment.

Saini apprised the Singapore business community of Haryana's industrial ecosystem and investment opportunities. Discussions were held with representatives and experts from sectors including manufacturing, technology, logistics, energy, education and healthcare. — TNS

3 juveniles escape from F'bad correction home

SANJAY YADAV

FARIDABAD, OCTOBER 4

Three juveniles lodged in a correction home in the NIT area here escaped late last night after allegedly breaking open a window of an old bathroom, prompting the police to launch a search operation.

All three, aged around 17, were lodged at the facility in connection with separate murder cases. According to the police, two of them had

been staying at the correction home since 2024, while the third was admitted in 2025.

The juveniles allegedly broke a window of an old bathroom, lowered themselves onto a nursery located below it and then jumped down before fleeing the premises.

The police said security personnel were reportedly not present at the spot when the three escaped. The incident has raised questions over the security arrangements at the

correction home, and the authorities are investigating the circumstances that led to the escape.

The three juveniles are residents of Gurugram, Nuh and Hisar districts. After receiving information about the escape, police and Crime Branch teams began searching for them. Teams are conducting raids at suspected hideouts, while CCTV footage is being examined to trace their movements and identify the route they took

after fleeing the facility.

Inspector Mahabir Singh, SHO of NIT police station, said, “A complaint has been received from the juvenile correction home. The police are working to trace the trio's movements and the direction in which they fled by analysing CCTV footage. An investigation is also being conducted into how the window was dislodged so easily and why security personnel were not present at the time of the incident.”

Cong to hold marches over ‘vote theft’ on Oct 8

CHANDIGARH, OCTOBER 4

The Haryana Pradesh Congress Committee (HPCC) has announced massive protests in all districts of Haryana on October 8 as part of its ‘Save Vote-Save Nation’ campaign.

HPCC president Rao Narendra Singh said this week would be dedicated to the democratic set-up. “Along with the INDIA bloc parties, it has been decided to hold protests across Haryana on October 8,” he said.

A meeting of the INDIA bloc was held on September 30 at the Constitution Club of India in New Delhi. “The meeting discussed in detail issues related to the electoral process and voter lists,

alleged manipulation by the Chief Election Commissioner, ‘vote theft’, and the future joint action plan in this regard,” he said.

It was decided at the meeting that, as part of a comprehensive public awareness and outreach campaign on these issues, ‘Save Democracy Week’ would be observed from October 2 to 8. Accordingly, ‘Save Vote-Save Nation’ marches will be organised across all districts of Haryana.

He said the HPCC had already issued detailed instructions to all District Congress Committees regarding the campaign and the necessary coordination. — TNS

Hooda pushes for family outreach to expand base

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

KURUKSHETRA, OCTOBER 4

Former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Sunday said the Congress would appoint ‘Parivar Pramukhs’ and reach out to every family in the state as part of its efforts to strengthen the party's base.

Addressing a Congress workers' conference of the Thanesar block in Kurukshetra, Hooda accused the BJP of stealing votes and failing to take decisions in the public interest.

He said, “The BJP government has failed to provide MSP to farmers, employment to youth, security to women, and

respect to sportspersons and the elderly. As a result, every section of society has lost hope in the BJP. The truth has reached every household that the BJP formed its government in Haryana not through fair means, but through vote theft. All the evidence of this theft has now come to light.”

“While the BJP claims to have ‘Panna Pramukhs’, the Congress will appoint ‘Parivar Pramukhs’ and reach out to every family in the state. Party workers will take the message of Congress and Rahul Gandhi to every household,” he said, while calling upon workers to make sincere efforts to strengthen the party's base and counter the BJP.



Ishika, an Indian hockey team member, gets warm welcome in Bhiwani.

Ishika receives hero's welcome in Bhiwani

DEEPENDER DESWAL
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

BHIWANI, OCTOBER 4

Asian Games gold medallist Ishika Sambharwal received a grand welcome in her hometown Bhiwani on Sunday, with thousands of sports enthusiasts and residents lining the streets during a roadshow organised to celebrate her achievement.

Ishika, a member of the Indian women's hockey team that won gold at the Asian Games, was welcomed with garlands at Bhagat Singh Chowk. She travelled in an open vehicle through Dinod Gate and Hansi Gate before reaching her residence in Sector 13.

Expressing happiness over the reception, Ishika credited her success to her family, particularly her parents. “I am very happy to see so much love and support. I promise that I will continue to work hard,” she said.

She said the Asian Games victory had also secured

India's qualification for the Olympics. “There are two years left for the Olympics and we will work on every small aspect to make ourselves better. We will work hard to bring another gold medal for India,” she said.

Ishika dedicated the medal to her family and supporters, saying her father, Virender Singh, had been her first hockey coach and played a key role in shaping her career.

“I started playing hockey because of my father. After being selected for the junior team, I trained in Bengaluru and later joined the senior set-up,” she said.

Her father said he had recognised her potential at a young age and supported her throughout her journey. Bhiwani-Mahendragarh MP Dharambir Singh also visited the family and said it was a matter of pride for Bhiwani that Ishika had contributed to India's gold medal-winning campaign.

Rohtak village celebrates Deepika's Asian Games gold

RAVINDER SAINI
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

ROHTAK, OCTOBER 4

Indian women's hockey player Deepika Sehrawat received a warm welcome in her native Bhainsru Khurd village on Sunday after returning home following the team's historic gold-medal triumph at the Asian Games in Japan.

Villagers and family members greeted the player with flower garlands and celebrations, as people gathered in large numbers to congratulate Deepika, who was brought home in a cavalcade. She was also welcomed by people en route.

Deepika said the gold medal, which came after a 44-year wait, was the result of the team's hard work as well as the prayers and blessings of



Indian hockey player Deepika Sehrawat shows her gold medal on her return to Rohtak on Sunday. TRIBUNE PHOTO

people across the country.

“I was unaware that I was creating a record during the tournament, as my only focus was to give my best on the field and contribute to the team's victory. For a player, the team's victory is the most important thing. Records come later,” she said while speaking to the media on the occasion.

Recalling the tense moments of the final against China, Deepika said there was considerable pressure when the opposition was awarded a free stroke. “At that moment, I remembered God and prayed for the team's victory,” she added.

Deepika said she had been eagerly waiting to return home and meet her family, friends and fellow villagers after the tournament. “Coming back and being among my own people has given me immense happiness,” she said.

Her father, Jagdish Sehrawat, said the team's gold-medal triumph was a moment of immense pride for the family and the village. He said Deepika's strong start to the tournament helped boost the

team's confidence.

Jagdish said the entire village had come together to celebrate her achievement, with residents gathering to congratulate the hockey player and organise a grand reception.

Deepika's grandmother, Phoolpati, also praised her performance. “Well done, daughter! You did a wonderful job. You played exceptionally well and made us proud,” she said.

Interestingly, Deepika's sporting journey began in childhood, not on a hockey field but at a wrestling facility in Hisar, where she accompanied her elder brother. Her father worked as a laboratory assistant at Haryana Agricultural University. Now retired, he lives in his native village.

Sonepat MLA felicitates medallists

MUKESH TANDON
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

SONEPAT, OCTOBER 4

Sonepat MLA Nikhil Madan on Sunday met Indian women hockey players Sakshi Rana and Jyoti at their residences and felicitated them for being part of the team that won the gold medal at the Asian Games. Congratulating the players on their achievement, Madan said their success was a matter of pride for Sonepat, Haryana and the country. He said their journey reflected the importance of hard work, discipline, determination and sustained practice in achieving sporting excellence.

“Sakshi Rana and Jyoti have brought laurels to the country with their talent and hard work. Their achievement is particularly significant as the Indian



MLA Nikhil Madan with Jyoti at her residence in Sonepat.

women's hockey team ended the country's 44-year wait for an Asian Games medal,” he said.

Madan said the two players would inspire the younger generation, particularly girls, to pursue their goals with confidence and perseverance.

He highlighted the difficult circumstances from which the two players had emerged. Sak-

shi Rana's father, Satpal Rana, used to run a canteen at Tikaram Girls Senior Secondary School for a living. Jyoti Ramawat lost her father at a young age and her mother died two years ago. Her grandmother, Murti Devi, played a key role in supporting her journey in sport, he said.

Madan also praised Arjuna Awardee coach Pritam Siwach, under whose guidance the players were trained, saying her contribution to the Indian women's hockey team's success was commendable. He congratulated Siwach for her role in nurturing the players.

The MLA wished Sakshi and Jyoti success in their future competitions and expressed hope that they would continue to bring laurels to the state and the country.

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COURT NOTICES

(U/O 5 Rule 20 CPC)

In the Court of Ms. Savreen Sandhu Civil Judge (Junior Division)-19, Jalandhar Raj Rani Versus Raj

CNR No.: PBJL02-000824-2020
Next Date: 23.10.2026

Suit for grant of decree of Permanent Injunction as prayed for Publication issued to:

1. Raj legal heir of deceased Sh. Darshan Lal s/o Late Piarla Lal r/o Maqsuban Jalandhar, 2. Manisha, 3. Chand legal heir of deceased Ashwani s/o Late Sh. Darshan Lal s/o Late Piarla Lal r/o Mohalla Rishi Nagar VPO Alawalpur Ward No. 4, Jal. 4. Heena, 5. Neha, 6. Shikha, 7. Priya, 8. Mani, 9. Karan all legal heir of deceased Sh. Ravinder Thapar s/o Late Sh. Piarla Lal r/o Mohalla Rishi Nagar VPO Alawalpur Ward No. 4, Jalandhar, 10. Veena Hans w/o Late Sh. Mangal Ram Hans r/o Village Sunet near Water Tank, Ludhiana.

In above titled case, the defendant(s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 23.10.2026 at 10.00 a.m.

For details logon to https://highcourthd.gov.in/?mod=district_notice&district=jalandhar

Dated, this day of 03.10.2026, Sd/- Civil Judge (Junior Division)-19, Jalandhar

CL26043304

(U/O 5 Rule 20 CPC)

In the Court of Sh. Kaushal Kumar Yadav Civil Judge (Jr. Divn.) Chandigarh RD Mittal Vs.

General Public CNR No.

CHCH02-006787-2026
Next Date: 11.11.2026

Publication issued to:

General Public :-

Chandigarh

In above titled case, the defendant(s)/respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 11.11.2026 at 10.00 a.m.

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Dated, this day of 24.09.2026.

Sd/- Civil Judge (Jr. Division)

CL26052141 Chandigarh

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Long-awaited Delhi-Karnal rapid rail corridor gets fresh policy push

Move paves way for planned development around proposed stations

PARVEEN ARORA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

KARNAL, OCTOBER 4

The long-awaited Delhi-Panipat-Karnal rapid rail project has received a fresh push with the Haryana Government formally including the corridor in its Transit Oriented Development (TOD) Policy, raising hopes among residents that work on the project will gain momentum.

The Town and Country Planning Department, in a notification issued recently, amended the policy notified in 2016 to include the Delhi-Panipat-Karnal Namoo Bharat Regional Rapid Transit System corridor among the Mass Rapid Transit System corridors eligible for transit-oriented development.

The notification said the corridor had been approved by the state government on the recommendation of the Haryana Mass Rapid Transport Corporation. Following a request from the corporation, the alignment has now been



incorporated into the annexure of the existing policy.

The project was initially planned from Sarai Kale Khan in Delhi to Panipat. It was later extended to Karnal by then Chief Minister Manohar Lal Khattar in January 2020.

Karnal was included in the National Capital Region in June 2015, raising expectations of improved connectivity and modern infrastructure. Residents have since been awaiting direct rapid transit connectivity with Delhi.

The proposed corridor will connect Narela, Kundli, Sonapat, Murthal, Ganaur, Samalkha, Panipat, Gharaunda and Karnal, besides other proposed and future stations.

In Karnal, the proposed stations include Karnal ISBT, Sector 7, Gharaunda and Kohand, with Karnal bypass listed as a future station. The Panipat section is proposed to have stations at Panipat city, Sewah and Samalkha, besides Sector 18 as a future station. The Sonapat section

includes Ganaur, Murthal, Bahalgarh Chowk and Kundli, with Barhi and KMP as future stations.

The inclusion under the TOD policy is expected to provide a planning framework for development around proposed transit stations, including better connectivity, mixed land use and higher-density development.

"The inclusion of the corridor in the TOD policy means development around the proposed transit network can be undertaken within an established planning framework. It will save time and fuel for commuters travelling daily between Karnal and Delhi," said social activist Anshul Narang.

Deepak Bareja, a local resident, said people in Karnal and neighbouring districts had been waiting for direct rapid transit connectivity with Delhi for years. "The notification is another step towards strengthening our hopes," he said.

Vij meets Rajnath, seeks Army land for hospital expansion

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

AMBALA, OCTOBER 4

Cabinet Minister Anil Vij on Sunday met Defence Minister Rajnath Singh in New Delhi and sought the transfer of Army land adjoining the Civil Hospital in Ambala Cantonment to facilitate the hospital's expansion.

The demand pertains to nearly 20 acres of defence land adjacent to the hospital, which the Health Department says is required for decongesting the existing facility and undertaking proposed expansion projects.

An extension block of the Civil Hospital is already under construction, but officials have maintained that additional land is essential to meet future healthcare needs in the cantonment area.

The issue had earlier been highlighted by *The Tribune* in a report titled "Land shortage clouds Ambala Civil Hospital expansion plans" published on July 16.

This is not the first time the matter has been taken up with the Defence Ministry.



Cabinet Minister Anil Vij meets Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

Vij had made a similar request last year as well, but Army authorities had reportedly expressed reservations citing security concerns and limited availability of land.

Sharing photographs of the meeting on social media, Vij said he had

urged the Defence Minister to transfer the adjoining defence land to the Haryana Government for the hospital's expansion. According to the minister, Rajnath Singh gave a positive assurance on the request.

Street protest



Anganwadi workers raise slogans during a protest over their various demands in Gurugram on Sunday. PTI



Haryana Diary

Congress plans training camps for workers

Hisar: The Congress is planning to organise prashikshan shivirs (training camps) for its workers in Haryana. Party incharge for Haryana Sanjay Dutt said in Uchana town of Jind district that the ongoing block-level meetings were aimed at strengthening the party organisation. Party leaders maintained that, with the new organisational structure in place, workers were making efforts to strengthen the grassroots network. Dutt said the party would soon organise training camps to equip workers to connect with people by highlighting what it described as the government's anti-people policies.

Haryana Cong finds new energy amid internal factionalism

Yamunanagar: Factionalism may continue to haunt the Haryana Congress, with leaders from different camps often reluctant to attend one another's programmes, but the party appears to have found renewed energy in its role as the principal Opposition. Its increasingly active political campaign has created an atmosphere that makes Haryana appear to be in election mode, even though no Assembly polls are on the immediate horizon. The irony is hard to miss. While the Congress continues to grapple with internal differences, its leaders have been raising a series of political issues and attempting to corner the ruling establishment. From questioning the functioning of constitutional institutions to raising demands concerning the Chief Election Commissioner, the party has been trying to keep the government on the defensive.

BKU (Charuni) chief blames farmers for lack of unity

Kurukshetra: Amid the ongoing struggle to ensure smooth paddy procurement, Bhar-

tiya Kisan Union (Charuni) president Gurnam Singh Charuni has expressed unhappiness over the lack of participation by farmers in protests. During a recent protest in Kurukshetra, the BKU leader appeared miffed by the low turnout and, while calling for another protest on October 5, blamed farmers for the lack of unity and the prevailing situation. Charuni said that because of this lack of unity, the government was not taking farmers seriously. He urged union members and other farm organisations to participate in the protest to ensure their demands were met.

Officials on toes as paddy procurement begins

Karnal: With paddy procurement underway, officials are on their toes to ensure a smooth and transparent process across the district. Authorities are leaving no stone unturned to prevent any possibility of "ghost procurement", a concern that surfaced in previous years. Officials are closely monitoring arrivals, verification, gate passes, moisture levels and the lifting of procured stock. Field staff and procurement agencies have been directed to remain vigilant and ensure that every transaction is properly recorded on the portal. The administration is also keeping a close watch on the movement of paddy to prevent diversion and ensure that genuine farmers receive timely payment for their produce.

Ex-Congress MLA makes controversial remarks

Jhajjar: Former Congress MLA Rajendra Singh Joon courted controversy during a Congress workers' meeting in Bahadurgarh on Sunday with his 'rakshas' (demon) remark against a former INLD MLA while referring to the 2005 Assembly elections. Joon also cautioned Congress leaders, saying there were many 'chugalkhors' (tattlers) in Bahadurgarh who recorded videos and showed them to others. He urged party leaders not to pay heed to them.



GEETANJALI GAYATRI

IN a week that saw the Haryana Government seek an extension in service from the Centre for senior IAS officer Arun Kumar Gupta, who retired earlier this week, the government also "accommodated" former DGP OP Singh as the CEO of SANKALP to create awareness on the growing drug and substance abuse. Singh had retired in December last year.

A number of retired bureaucrats continue to serve the government in various capacities — as heads or members of various commissions in the state.

Gupta, who was serving as Principal Secretary to the Chief Minister and Additional Chief Secretary (Finance), was expected to step into a new role right after his retirement, given that he is considered close to Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini.

Though the state government had sent a proposal

seeking a one-year service extension for Gupta, the Centre did not respond to the request, leaving the state with no option but to issue his retirement orders. However, the possibility of his being appointed to one of the many state commissions remains, and it might happen sooner than later, if sources in the government are to be believed.

This is not the first time that service extensions and appointments of top officers have been up for debate in bureaucratic circles. The two service extensions granted to 1990-batch IAS officer Anurag Rastogi — currently serving as Chief Secretary — had also stirred up the bureaucracy.

Rastogi was appointed to the top bureaucratic post after superseding four senior IAS officers, against the backdrop of an unresolved seniority dispute involving officers of the 1990 batch. He was chosen over two senior batchmates, Sudhir

Rajpal and Sumita Mishra, who ranked above him in the Haryana IAS officers' gradation list.

Before he was posted as Chief Secretary, Rastogi, along with batchmates Ankur Gupta and Raj Sekhar Vundru — both of whom have since retired — had challenged their seniority, arguing that Rajpal and Mishra should be placed below them as they had been inducted into the Haryana cadre through inter-cadre transfers from Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir, respectively.

Granting service extensions to senior bureaucrats also creates resentment among other officers who are next in line for key posts.

"When an officer continues in a top position beyond the normal retirement age, other eligible officers in the hierarchy have to wait longer for their turn. Such an extension denies some of them

the opportunity to serve in a post they could have otherwise got based on their seniority. While the government grants extensions for continuity or administrative reasons, such decisions affect the career prospects of other senior officers and create a sense of dissatisfaction within the bureaucracy," said an IAS officer on condition of anonymity.

All eyes are now on the state government to see whether it has any retirement plan for Arun Kumar Gupta. The bureaucracy is abuzz with speculation that the former Principal Secretary to the Chief Minister could be given a key post.

With a couple of IAS and IPS officers due to retire by the end of this year and Rastogi's term extension ending in December, it remains to be seen how many officers the government is willing to hold on to while letting others go.

Panic among residents as leopard kills calf in Y'nagar village

YAMUNANAGAR, OCTOBER 4

Panic gripped Mugalwahi village in Yamunanagar district after a leopard allegedly killed a calf. According to villagers, the leopard entered a cattle yard, killed a calf and dragged it towards the forest. Some residents later spotted the animal eating the carcass and informed the Wildlife Department. The incident has caused concern among villagers, particularly farmers who frequently work in fields adjoining the forest area.

"Farmers are worried about their safety and that of their cattle as they frequently work in agricultural fields adjoining the forest area," a villager said. The villagers have urged the Wildlife Department to monitor the leopard's movement and take preventive measures to avoid any untoward incident. Inspector Litu Ram of the Wildlife Department said villagers had been advised to remain alert while going to their fields, particularly during the evening and night, and avoid venturing alone into isolated areas near the forest. — TNS

BKU mahapanchayat raises key farmers' issues in Yamunanagar

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

YAMUNANAGAR, OCTOBER 4

The Bharatiya Kisan Union (Tikait) organised a mahapanchayat at a rest area on the Saharanpur-Panchkula National Highway in Aurangabad village of Yamunanagar district on Sunday to raise farmers' issues.

A large number of farmers, including BKU national spokesperson Rakesh Tikait, arrived at the mahapanchayat on tractors. Various demands of farmers were discussed during the gathering.

At the mahapanchayat, farmers demanded an increase in the price of sugarcane to Rs 600 per quintal, a rise in the permissible moisture content of paddy from 17 to 22 per cent, the cancellation of the trade deal with the United States, a waiver of farmers' loans and a substantial increase in the price of wheat.

The farmers wanted to submit a memorandum listing these demands to district administration offi-

cials, but initially no official arrived at the venue.

Rakesh Tikait expressed his displeasure over the situation and announced a highway blockade. Following the announcement, a large number of farmers moved towards the highway, and Tikait, along with others, sat on the road. Traffic on the Saharanpur-Panchkula National Highway-344 was disrupted, leading to a traffic jam for some time.

Later, Jagadhri SDM Vishwanath reached the spot after receiving information about the highway blockade. He spoke with the farmers and accepted their memorandum of demands. Tikait said whatever decision Haryana farmers took, the BKU would stand by them.

Woman, man found dead in canal near Bahadurgarh

JHAJJAR, OCTOBER 4

A woman and a man were found dead under mysterious circumstances in the NCR Minor near Bahadurgarh on Sunday.

The bodies were found floating in the canal near a bridge on the road connecting Jasaur Kheri and Bhainsru villages. The bodies appeared to be several days old.

Some villagers noticed the bodies and informed the police. A police team reached the spot and sent the bodies to the Civil Hospital, Bahadurgarh, for post-mortem examination.

The identities of the deceased were yet to be established. The woman was wearing a suit, while the man was wearing a T-shirt and underwear. The police said efforts were underway to establish the identities of the deceased. — TNS

REMEMBRANCE

We fondly remember the Pillar of our family
Late Mrs. Harminder Kaur
who was snatched from us by cruel & untimely death on 05/10/2020

Remembered by
Er. Gurdev Singh (Husband), CE Retd. Pb. Irr Dept.
& Family, Relatives & Friends. 98787-00478



Late Sdn. Harminder Kaur
17.06.1958 - 05.10.2020

Assembly session likely from Oct 23

RUCHIKA M KHANNA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

CHANDIGARH, OCTOBER 4
The state government is likely to convene the winter session of the Vidhan Sabha from October 23 to 27, with issues concerning farmers expected to figure prominently in the proceedings. Official sources said the Cabinet is set to consider the proposal on Monday. The proposed session would include holidays on October 24 and 25. The move follows a commitment made to farmer unions during their September 1-7 protest at the Chandigarh borders that their key demands would be taken up in the Assembly. During the farmers’ protest, held under the aegis of the Samyukta Kisan Morcha, Agriculture Minister Gurmeet Singh Khudian had assured the protesting unions that an assembly session would be convened to consider their demands. Among the issues expected to come up is the farmers’ demand for reconsideration of existing water agreements and adoption of a resolution against provisions of the Punjab Reorganisation Act relating to river waters. The Assembly is also likely to consider resolutions opposing the Dam Safety Act and the Seed Bill, 2025, as sought by the farmer organisations.

2 former sarpanches murdered in Ludhiana, Bathinda attacks

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

LUDHIANA/BATHINDA, OCTOBER 4
Two former sarpanches were murdered in Ludhiana and Bathinda districts during the past 24 hours. Navtej Singh Neetu (57), former sarpanch of Manewal village in Ludhiana, was shot dead on Saturday evening, while Jagtar Singh (65) was hacked to death with an axe outside a liquor vend at Jassi Pauwali Chowk in Bathinda district on Sunday evening. The Ludhiana police have booked seven persons in connection with the murder of Navtej Singh Neetu, including his cousin. The preliminary investigation points towards a long-standing land dispute between the victim and his cousin, with the police suspecting that contract killers may have been engaged to execute the killing. Navtej was returning home from his fields at Manewal when two motorcycle-borne assailants intercepted his Toyota Innova on Saturday evening and opened fire. Around 10 shots were fired on the moving vehicle from a .30 bore pistol, leaving Navtej with multiple bullet injuries. He died on the spot. A land dispute between Navtej and his cousin is already pending in a local



Police inspect the murder spot on the outskirts of Bathinda on Sunday.



CONTRACT KILLERS MAY BE INVOLVED

- The police suspect the involvement of contract killers in the murder of Navtej Singh in Ludhiana
- Dashcam footage helped investigators identify one of the motorcycle-borne suspects

court, while a related case is also before the Punjab and Haryana High Court. The police said the two had allegedly quarrelled and threatened each other in the past. Police Commissioner Swapan Sharma said the initial investigation suggested that Navtej’s cousin might have hatched the conspiracy to eliminate him over a property dispute. The suspects have reportedly locked their houses and fled. A major lead for the investigators is the dashcam

installed in Navtej’s car. The police said the camera captured two motorcycle-borne assailants during the attack. Investigators have managed to identify one of the suspects, but his identity has not been disclosed so far. “The initial investigation suggests that the murder was linked to a property dispute. We are also examining the role of those who may have been hired to carry out the killing,” the commissioner said. He said six police teams, working under the supervi-

sion of a deputy commissioner of police, had been formed to trace the suspects. The police are examining the dashcam footage, CCTV recordings and other evidence to establish the sequence of events and identify all those involved in the murder. Further investigation is underway. In Bathinda district, Jagtar Singh, alias Tara, a resident of Phus Mandi village, had reportedly gone to the liquor vend to buy liquor when he was attacked. According to his relatives, Jagtar Singh was initially hit with an axe twice. The attacker later returned from a nearby chowk and attacked him again and fled. Jagtar succumbed to his injuries. The incident took place in the presence of the public, but nobody came forward to intervene, relatives of the deceased claimed. His brother said he was not aware of any enmity involving the deceased. The police have arrested the accused, identified as Gurbaksh Singh of the same Phus Mandi village, along with the weapon used to commit the crime. Bathinda SP (City) Aaswant Singh visited the spot and said the accused and the deceased had a personal enmity.

NGT seeks state’s reply over Sutlej, Sirhind canal pollution

LALIT MOHAN
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

ROPAR, OCTOBER 4
The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has sought a response from the state government and other respondents over allegations of pollution in the Sutlej river and Sirhind Canal at Ropar, including the alleged release of industrial waste accumulated at the Ropar Headworks in August 2026. The matter was taken up by the NGT Principal Bench, headed by Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and Expert Member Dr Afroz Ahmad, on an application filed by Ropar resident Gurbaksh Singh Gill. The Tribunal issued notice on September 24 and listed the matter for hearing on December 2, 2026, alongside a case concerning alleged pollution by pharmaceutical industries in Himachal Pradesh’s Baddi-Barotiwala-Nalagarh industrial belt. The petition alleges that large quantities of solid, chemical and biomedical waste originating from the BBN industrial area accumulated at the Ropar Headworks in August. Instead of being removed for proper disposal and scientific sampling, the material was allegedly allowed to pass downstream after the Headworks gates were opened. The applicant has sought

ALLEGATIONS UNDER SCRUTINY	
■ Industrial waste allegedly accumulated at Ropar Headworks during August raising concerns	stances behind Headworks gate operations
■ Polluted material was allegedly released downstream after gates opened into canal	■ Untreated sewage enters Sutlej through four Ropar locations affecting water quality
■ Petition seeks records explaining circum-	■ Applicant seeks inspection, compensation and periodic compliance reports for action

an inquiry into who ordered the opening of the gates and under what circumstances the accumulated waste was released into the Sirhind Canal. According to the application, photographs of the accumulated material were taken and an FIR was registered on August 23 against unidentified industrial units in the Baddi-Nalagarh area. The petition alleges that the following day, the accumulated waste and polluted material were released downstream. It refers to the Executive Engineer, Ropar Headworks, as having confirmed the release. The applicant has sought preservation and production of gate operation records, orders, logbooks, CCTV footage and other relevant official records to ascertain the circumstances surrounding the opening of the gates. The Sirhind Canal originates at the Ropar Head-

works and carries Sutlej water towards the Malwa region through various canal systems. The water is used for drinking, livestock and irrigation across several districts. The petition alleges that releasing the accumulated material downstream effectively shifted the pollution problem instead of containing and scientifically examining it. The application has also raised concerns over the alleged discharge of untreated or inadequately treated sewage from Ropar town into the Sutlej and Sirhind Canal. The complainant has identified four alleged discharge points, including the Haveli Kalan Sewage Treatment Plant, an open effluent channel near Bara Phool village, an outfall towards the Sutlej near IIT Ropar road, and a discharge point near Sant Nirankari Satsang Bhawan/Basant Nagar.

Pargat Singh at Congress helm, Charanjit Channi trends cautiously ahead of poll

RAJMEET SINGH
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

CHANDIGARH, OCTOBER 4
As the newly-appointed Punjab Congress chief Pargat Singh officially takes over his new assignment at Punjab Congress Bhavan this week, former CM Charanjit Singh Channi, while welcoming the appointment, is adopting a politically cautious and measured approach. In a tweet, the Jalandhar MP backed the Congress high command’s decision, indicating that he does not want a fresh bout of confrontation with the party leadership. However, the appointment has reportedly disappointed sections of the Channi camp, who were hoping for a state Congress chief more closely aligned with their group. Party insiders said during the deliberations held over the last two days, the leaders in the Channi camp were keen on tweaking the PPCC body to accommodate one of the senior Hindu leaders as a working president. At present, Sangat Singh Gilzian, an OBC leader, Sukhwinder Singh Danny and Raj Kumar Verka — both Dalit leaders, are working presidents. The Channi camp also wanted its interests to be watched while finalising tickets in



Newly appointed state Congress chief Pargat Singh with senior party leader Ambika Soni at her residence in New Delhi.

the screening committee, said sources. By appointing Pargat Singh, who has his own political standing and a distinct identity, the Congress high command, while acceding to the demand for change of the Punjab affairs in-charge Bhupesh Baghel and PPCC chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, has created a lead-

ership arrangement that was not dominated by any single faction. Channi and Gurdaspur MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa were keen on becoming the PPCC chief, but the top leadership has indicated that it will not buckle under pressure. A senior leader said though Warring has been removed following a report by Punjab

affairs in-charge Sachin Pilot, the former PPCC chief cannot be totally ignored. Over the last four-and-a-half years, Warring has appointed office-bearers to various positions. His demand for certain tickets at the time of candidate selection cannot be ruled out in light of his recent meeting with party leader Rahul Gandhi. After intense infighting between the Warring and Channi camps, which led to Baghel and Warring’s exit, the high command is closely watching Channi’s response and actions, as he remains an important face of the Congress in Punjab. Pargat Singh has already announced plans to bring together different factions and rebuild the party’s organisational strength. His ability to maintain a working relationship with Channi and other influential Congress leaders will be critical. Channi, who heads the Campaign Committee, is planning a cycle yatra. Though Channi did not respond to calls, leaders in his camp said efforts were being made to work out an adjustment. “The immediate political challenge for Channi was to maintain a cooperative public posture while protecting his influence within the state unit”, said a senior party leader.

Women brand ambassadors of Satkar Yojana, says CM Mann

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

CHANDIGARH, OCTOBER 4
Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Sunday declared every mother and sister in the state is a brand ambassador of the Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojana, describing the initiative as a social revolution aimed at strengthening women’s dignity, self-respect and financial autonomy. Mann said more than 75 lakh women had registered under the scheme, with Rs 3,824 crore already transferred directly into beneficiaries’ bank accounts as Sanman Rashi. He said the scheme was intended to usher in a new era of financial empowerment for women across the state. “This is the first scheme of its kind in the country under which all eligible women are being provided Satkar Rashi,” Mann said, adding that the state government had launched the scheme in recognition of women’s dignity and respect. According to Mann, women above the age of 18 are receiving mobile notifications regarding financial assistance of Rs 1,000, while eligible Scheduled Caste women are receiv-



CM Bhagwant Mann embraces a beneficiary of Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojana in Chandigarh on Sunday. TRIBUNE PHOTO

FINANCIAL EMPOWERMENT	
■ ₹9,300 cr allocated for scheme in state budget.	women's dignity and autonomy.
■ ₹3,824 cr transferred directly into beneficiaries' bank accounts.	■ Eligible women urged to complete registration and benefit.
■ Government says scheme strengthens	■ Over 75 lakh women have registered under scheme.

ing Rs 1,500. The CM said around 97 per cent of women in the state were expected to benefit from the scheme. He added that the government had allocated Rs 9,300 crore in the budget for the initiative and that the assistance was being transferred directly into benefi-

ciaries’ bank accounts. Mann said the direct-transfer mechanism was intended to ensure that financial assistance reached eligible women without intermediaries. He reiterated that the scheme was focused on providing women with greater financial support while reinforcing their dignity.

Narrowescape for ASI in gun attack in Ajnala

AMRITSAR, OCTOBER 4
Sukhchain Singh, Assistant Sub-Inspector (ASI) posted in the GRP, was shot at by three bike-borne persons at Jagdev Kalan village in Ajnala on Sunday evening. Sukhchain was returning from Amritsar to Ajnala on his bike. He said when he reached near Jagdev Kalan village, three unidentified persons fired shots at him. A bullet grazed past Sukhchain’s arm. Alarmed by the incident, he sped away and reached home, taken to hospital.—TNS

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed that the properties of MR Enclave, MR Gold etc. are under litigation in a Civil Court at Fazilka titled as "Pransh Gilhotra Vs Sabina Arora etc." bearing Case No. CS/735/2026. The general public at large along with Sub Registrars / Registrars/ All Banks officials, through notice are hereby informed & cautioned that if anybody indulge in any sort of transaction i.e. sale, transfer or any sort of alienation with Mrs Sabina Arora or their agents or representatives, he/she will be doing at his own risk and would be dragged in the aforesaid civil suit as party to the litigation. If vendors produce any order of any court, that should be verified from court, leagal department & any competent authority. Anil kumar Jain Advocate, Fazilka P/663/1982 Shrenik Jain Advocate, Fazilka P/727/2011

From Jalandhar village to Asian Games glory, Manpreet, Mandeep make their families proud

APARNA BANERJI
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

MITHAPUR (JALANDHAR), OCT 4
“Mata tere mann di tamanna puri ho gayi” — a jubilant Manpreet Singh called his mother as the men’s Indian hockey team bagged gold at the Asian Games by defeating Malaysia 5-1 in the final. A home-cooked ‘Saag’ and roti, prepared by his mother Manjit Kaur, and a special langar for kids at ‘Pingalwara’ and ‘Unique Home’, an orphanage for girls, are among the special plans of ace Hockey player and former India captain Manpreet as he



Family members of Indian hockey player Mandeep Singh in jubilant mood at Mithapur in Jalandhar. TRIBUNE PHOTO

returns home tomorrow. Manpreet’s close friend and fellow villager Mandeep

Singh’s mother Devinderjit Kaur and wife Uditia Duhan, also a hockey player, also beam

with pride. Mandeep is also a member of the Indian team that won the top medal. With their homes just a stone’s throw from each other, their families have barely had time to catch their breath amid congratulatory visits, calls from relatives and friends, and visits by village youths. With 430 international appearances, Manpreet has become the most capped player in Indian men’s field hockey. He has also become the first Indian player to secure three medals in Asian Games. Mandeep has 312 international caps.

₹25 wheat MSP hike ‘cruel joke’: Farmers

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

BATHINDA, OCTOBER 4
The Bharti Kisan Union (Ekta Ugrahan) has said that the increase in the minimum support price (MSP) of wheat by Rs 25 to Rs 2,610 per quintal for the rabi season is a “cruel joke” on farmers by the Centre. Union’s state unit president Joginder Singh Ugrahan, senior vice-president Jhanda Singh Jethuke and state secretary Shingara Singh Mann said the hike amounted to just 25 paise per kg. It was less than 1 per

cent, he said. They said the nominal increase reflected a policy aimed at pushing farmers out of agriculture. They alleged that the Centre was also moving towards allowing American agricultural produce into Indian markets under a proposed India-US trade agreement, which, they claimed, would weaken the domestic agricultural market and the existing mandi system. The farm leaders said the prices of fertilisers, agricultural inputs and household goods had increased.

The Tribune

ESTABLISHED IN 1881

Asian gains

India did well to finish fourth despite setbacks

AFTER a sluggish start, India capitalised on a late surge to retain the fourth spot in the Asian Games. The 85-medal haul in Aichi-Nagoya — 21 gold, 27 silver and 37 bronze — kept India among the continent’s leading sporting nations, though nowhere near China and Japan. More importantly, the premier event revealed how tough it would be for the country to become an Olympic powerhouse over the next decade or two. First, the positives. Archery fetched nine medals, including five gold, with teenager Kumkum Mohod being crowned India’s first individual Asiad champion in the recurve category. Boxing and wrestling delivered three and two gold medals, respectively, while Pranavi Urs became the first Indian woman to win an individual Asian Games golf gold. Indian players asserted their dominance in cricket, hockey and kabaddi. Powered by resilience and discipline, the women’s hockey team ended a 44-year wait for an Asian Games gold by edging out defending champions China in the final.

Athletics was a huge disappointment. The lone gold came from the women’s 4x400m relay team of Kiran Pahal, M Poovamma, Prachi Choudhary and Vithya Ramraj. Shooters, too, largely underperformed. Manu Bhaker, who won two bronze medals in the 2024 Paris Olympics, returned empty-handed from the Asiad. The contrast with the 2023 Hangzhou Games was stark. India’s record 106 medals, including 28 gold, had raised expectations of another historic campaign. Instead, the shortfall of 21 medals (including seven gold) is a timely warning.

The successes in Aichi-Nagoya must be celebrated, while lessons should be learnt from the failures. India’s sporting future cannot be built on individual brilliance or a late gold rush. The road to Olympic glory demands a bigger talent pool, better training, stronger mental conditioning and world-class support systems. The Asian Games have offered India a vital reality check. The next task is to initiate course correction in the run-up to the 2028 LA Olympics.

Green pilgrimage

Regulate numbers, plastics, mountain waste

A pilgrimage should leave a spiritual imprint, not a plastic one. But the Himalayas are increasingly bearing the burden of religious tourism. Kedarnath’s latest figures are a warning. The shrine generated 50.30 tonnes of waste between April and August — more than in any full year from 2023 to 2025. In contrast, nearly 5,000 pilgrims have carried over 12 tonnes of compressed plastic back down the 18-km trek under the ‘Carry Me Back’ campaign. The initiative deserves praise. It turns pilgrims into participants in conservation. But it cannot substitute for responsible tourism policy. The larger question is why so much waste reaches mountains. The problem extends beyond Kedarnath. More than 792 tonnes of waste had reportedly been collected during this year’s Char Dham pilgrimage by mid-September; with Hemkund Sahib and the Valley of Flowers, the figure crossed 800 tonnes. Plastic bottles, wrappers and disposables have been found above 3,000 metres. The lesson is unmistakable: the Himalayas are being treated as a consumption zone without adequate disposal capacity.

Reassuringly, there are positive examples. On the Amarnath route this year, reusable utensils and water-refilling facilities helped reduce waste per pilgrim by 15% despite a 17% rise in footfall. Such measures should become standard. Authorities must move from appeals to accountability: regulate single-use plastic, impose deposits on bottles and packaging, expand refill points, ensure source segregation and make vendors responsible for the waste their products create. Pilgrimage numbers must be aligned with scientifically assessed carrying capacities.

Devotion cannot mean exemption from environmental responsibility. Respecting the limits of a sacred mountain is part of respecting the faith it represents. Pilgrims can carry waste back. Governments must ensure that mountains are not made to carry the consequences of unchecked pilgrimage.

ON THIS DAY...100 YEARS AGO

The Tribune.

LAHORE, TUESDAY, OCTOBER 5, 1926

Swarajism versus responsivism

AT a time when the best of India’s sons, men who only yesterday were friends and comrades, have declared war upon one another, when mutual bitterness and recrimination have reached its culminating point, and when all over the country the only voice one hears is the voice of strife, it does one’s heart good to disengage oneself for a moment from current controversies and seek such consolation as one can find in philosophy, the sheet anchor of despairing humanity. Is the position as disclosed by the existence of too many mutually antagonistic parties in India, each with its distinctive shibboleths and war cries, so utterly hopeless as it does appear at the outset? Let the question be answered by one of the most illustrious of Germans, in fact, of all modern philosophers. “A party,” says Hegel, “first truly shows itself to have won the victory when it breaks up into two parties; for so it proves that it contains in itself the principle with which it first had to conflict. The interest which formerly divided itself between it and that to which it was opposed now falls entirely within itself, and the opposing principle is left behind and forgotten, just because it is represented by one of the sides in the new controversy which now occupies the minds of men. In this point of view, that discord which appears at first to be a lamentable breach and dissolution of the unity of a party, is really the crowning proof of its success.” In making these observations, Hegel was thinking not of political parties, but of schools of philosophical thought, but his words are just as applicable to the one as they are to the other. They are literally applicable to our own case.

OPINION

Punjab beset by narco-terrorism

Easy availability of narcotics and illicit arms makes the border state highly vulnerable



MANISH TEWARI
LOK SABHA MP AND
FORMER I&B MINISTER

PAKISTAN’s strategy of bleeding India with a thousand cuts has another sinister manifestation — narco-terrorism. It is the silent, creeping poison that flows across the northwestern border. It has emerged as an existential threat to the security architecture and social fabric of north-west India, particularly Punjab.

Globally, the core of narco-terrorism is fundamentally profit-driven. Violence is viewed as a necessary means to protect and expand lucrative operations rather than as an end in itself. In Punjab, however, the pursuit of profit has also been aimed at promoting and financing terrorism, separatism and radicalisation.

The foundations of the drug-terror nexus plaguing India were laid over two centuries of geopolitical machinations. The opium commerce, which first enriched the Venetians and later the Portuguese, the Dutch and the British, was a tool of economic warfare long before it became a source of terror financing.

The British East India Company, through its monopoly on Indian poppy fields, used opium to balance its trade deficits with China. This cultivation stretched along a succession of mountain ranges from Turkey to Japan, including the regions that now form the Golden Crescent. Drug production and trade in the Indian subcontinent evolved and adapted to the market, be it opium, heroin, amphetamines, Ecstasy or designer drugs.

Simultaneously, weapons trafficking in the Golden Crescent (including Balochistan) has a long history entwined with the drug trade. The Makran coast, once a conduit for slaves and gold, evolved into a smuggling route for firearms destined for Afghans resisting the British, a



MENACE : The escalating influx of drugs feeds a ticking time bomb for Punjab. FILE PHOTO

tradition of arms trafficking that the colonial government itself inadvertently nurtured by licensing local arms manufacturers along the Durand Line to undercut foreign competition.

The drug-terror nexus began to expand when the weapons trade to both state and non-state actors on the black market became enormously profitable. Afghanistan’s poppy cultivation surged in the 1970s, and it became a global supplier of opiates when other countries in the region banned poppies. The Soviet invasion of Afghanistan (1979) catalysed the cross-border movement of weapons and narcotics in the region.

The ghost wars waged in Afghanistan by Western intelligence agencies and Pakistan’s Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) in the 1980s provided the political protection and logistical framework that connected Afghanistan’s poppy fields through Pakistan’s heroin laboratories to markets in America and Europe. This effectively created the Frankenstein’s monster that the entire region confronts today.

By 1989, after a decade of covert operations, Afghanistan and Pakistan ranked as the world’s largest and second-largest suppliers of illicit heroin, respectively. The drug trade became an important fund-raising activity. The theological justification was: “We are making drugs to neutralise the Western infidels. If we cannot kill them with guns, we will kill them with drugs.”

The Union govt may claim success in reducing terror incidents, but the narcotics network which once sustained that terror has metastasised.

This period saw the active encouragement of poppy cultivation by Pakistan’s military dictator Gen Zia-ul-Haq, who patronised it as a lucrative method to fund operations of terrorist groups targeting India.

By the late 1980s, about 70 per cent of the heroin processed in Pakistan was being sold on the international market. Pakistan’s National Logistics Cell, created ostensibly to transport weapons to the Afghan border, also facilitated the movement of opiates back to the port of Karachi.

Following the Soviet withdrawal, as Western aid evaporated and civil war consumed Afghanistan, the opium economy replaced foreign patronage as the primary source of paramilitary financing, with existing arms smuggling routes perfectly suited for drug trafficking.

THOUGHT FOR THE DAY

We have created a roadmap to achieve the milestone of making India drug-free by 2029. — Amit Shah

Computers came and chaos followed

SHIRISH KOYAL

If you touch this computer, you will be instantly vaporised — the warning was dire, its floating animation and changing colours adding to its hideousness. I had read that people were done away with by more civilised methods, but not by vaporisation. When a reporter in my newspaper office touched the computer and resumed filing his report, my bewilderment rose. How was he still solid and unscathed? I later learnt that he had put up the message as a screensaver to keep his story away from prying eyes!

Using computers in the early 1990s to type and edit stories was a novel experience for us journalists. On average, our work would halt twice a week on receiving the message: “Error finding server”. However hard we tried to type or save, we were stuck; the only way out was rebooting our machines. Having lost their work, some journalists would literally cry.

It was a time when the computer department had found a way to convert news agency feed to digital format. One afternoon, a desk colleague walked into the systems room and said, “I want it loaded.” The computer guy who heard this rushed out with a look of puzzlement and worry. We reassured him that our co-worker was not talking about guns and ammunition; he just wanted to edit a story he had selected on WordStar.

Making pages on computers was meant to be pure joy: trim stories, rework headlines, change the arrangement of stories — a dynamic that didn’t depend on anybody’s whims. In reality, it was pure pain. Stories would take a long time to save, and pages would often crash.

An eager beaver keen to edit and paginate, I asked the systems head why we were not using an in-house pagination program. “We aren’t finding the driver for it,” he replied. Now what did a person who holds the steering wheel and shifts gears have to do with running software? That would have been too silly to ask. I never broached that topic again.

In 1991, employees of the typesetting, proofreading, pagination and camera departments went on strike. The management decided to prove that the paper could be produced without them. With us novices and temporary staff, work dragged way beyond the deadline. At 2 am, I was called to take a phone call. After the two-minute conversation ended, the chief reporter, seeing me crestfallen, said, “Wife abused you? I know.”

The management did prove its point that night. But the last page was released — by yours truly — at 7.35 am.

The writer is a journalist and educator based in Bengaluru

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Victory comes by staying on track

With reference to “The tough race to the finish line” (*The Great Game*); this is India’s paradox — *Beti bachao* on posters, but *beti* unsafe on streets. Our unscrupulous politicians lack the sportsmanship to reach the finish line. To win the race, they try to bypass the track. The Congress has done well by bringing in an ex-sportsman, former hockey captain Pargat Singh, as the PPCC president. India has a great future if we can remove non-performing politicians from the equation. Let’s salute our pilot, who risked his own life to save more than 170 passengers, and our players from humble backgrounds who have won medals. Let’s learn from our golden girls — victory comes by staying on the track, not by bribing the referee.

CAPT AMAR JEET (RETD), KHARAR

Women deserve better

Refer to “The tough race to the finish line”; our daughters, despite patriarchal prejudices and extreme levels of poverty and deprivation, have brought laurels to the nation. Yet we cannot ignore the ground reality that our women deserve much better from the State and society as a whole. Girls from Mizoram, Jharkhand, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Kerala have delivered mind-boggling performances at the Asian Games, and that should be an eye-opener for the people of Punjab and Haryana, both with skewed sex ratios.

RAJ BAHADUR YADAV, FATEHABAD

Technology to our aid

Apropos of ‘Allowing the Word to reach libraries and homes’; gone are the days when limited resources made the translation, interpretation and wider dissemination of scriptures difficult. Today, technology has placed powerful tools at our disposal to understand, translate and share this eternal wisdom across languages, generations and geographical boundaries. Academicians and librarians can play a meaningful role in this noble endeavour.

VK ANAND, CHANDIGARH

Understand scriptures

Apropos of ‘Allowing the Word to reach libraries and homes’; the true sanctity of any scripture lies in understanding its meaning and spirit, imbibing its teachings, and putting them into practice. All books of knowledge deserve to be treated with respect, though sacred texts may warrant special care out of consideration for the sentiments of their devoted followers. Interestingly, religious texts emphasise the importance of reading, understanding and listening attentively to their recitation. The true purpose of the holy Word is fulfilled only when its teachings are imbibed in the right spirit.

BILAL AHMAD SHAMIM, ANDAMAN ISLANDS

Don’t trust social media blindly

The violence at LPU, Phagwara, raises serious concerns. This highlights a worrying trend of campus unrest fuelled by GenZ networks, where a video spreads faster than verified facts. To prevent such incidents, three key steps are necessary. First, universities must address the information gap with a 24/7 crisis communication system, accessible faculty, and transparent grievance redressal. Second, police should quickly counter rumours by sharing verified information through official channels. Third, students must refrain from taking the law into their own hands.

ASHOK AGGARWAL, KURUKSHETRA

Listen to local party workers

Refer to ‘Cong banks on 3-time MLA Pargat to dribble Pb affairs ahead of poll’; ironically, all political parties professing deep faith in democracy are deviating from their path as the party high command is hand-picking state heads rather than letting local units have a say. Intra-party democracy would make the process transparent and curb factionalism. Votaries of democracy should realise that preaching and practice must go hand in hand.

ANIL VINAYAK, BY MAIL

At 25, Andaman Command faces uncertainty



ADMIRAL ARUN PRAKASH (RETD)
FORMER CHIEF OF NAVAL STAFF

ON October 8, as India's first joint military formation — the Andaman & Nicobar Command (ANC) — celebrates its silver jubilee, its fate hangs in balance. If and when the Indian armed forces adopt the "theatre command" model, the ANC may be either subsumed into a larger theatre or reorganised entirely. This milestone provides an opportune moment to evaluate the 25-year trajectory of what had begun, in 2001, as a bold leap of faith.

India is indeed fortunate to possess strategically located island territories in the Bay of Bengal, but such assets can become liabilities if adequate vision, foresight and planning expertise are not employed in their development. Closer to SE Asia than peninsular India, they form a springboard from where India can reach out and project power, or strike bonds of friendship in the neighbourhood.

We should be aware that the A&N islands have long been the objects of desire for those who wished to dominate the Bay of Bengal. In 1946, the

UK Chiefs of Staff recommended retaining the islands as a Crown colony and staging-post for air traffic to Australasia and the Far East. In 1947, Jinnah staked a claim to the islands as a link between East and West Pakistan; and during the 1965 Indo-Pakistani War, Indonesian President Sukarno, declaring the islands a geological extension of Sumatra, had threatened annexation.

The early roots of the Andaman and Nicobar Command go back to 1962, when alarmed at reported sightings of Chinese submarines in the Andaman Sea, the Navy positioned a small 150-man garrison, in Port Blair. With only 40 of the 572 major islands being inhabited, the Navy soon realised that the task of surveillance and guarding the 700-km long archipelago and its vast territorial waters against poachers, smugglers and infiltrators from five neighbouring countries was a major challenge. The Naval garrison was progressively reinforced, till in 1976, it was designated Fortress A&N (FORTAN), to be commanded by an admiral.

Requests for support from sister services evoked a mixed response. The army positioned, an under-size infantry brigade in Port Blair, and Vayu Bhavan inducted a small helicopter unit in IAF Station Car Nicobar. While the brigade was placed under FORTAN's command, the IAF retained control of its units, placing a



SILVER JUBILEE: The Andaman & Nicobar Command is India's first joint military formation. FILE

liaison officer in Port Blair.

Fast-forward to the year 2000: the Navy's proposal to upgrade FORTAN into a full-fledged "Far Eastern Naval Command" (FENC) was on the verge of receiving government approval. Concurrently, the post-Kargil Group of Ministers (GoM), chaired by Deputy PM LK Advani, was deliberating national security reforms. In Para 6.18 of its report, the GoM noted bluntly that "the Chiefs of Staff Committee (COSC) has not been effective in fulfilling its mandate" and urged that it "be strengthened by the addition of a Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) and a Vice CDS."

Emphasising that these measures would "promote greater jointness in the armed forces", the GoM recommended the immediate

Should
theaterisation
happen, there is
merit in earmarking
the ANC as a
standalone, forward
maritime outpost.

creation of a Joint Andaman and Nicobar Command, alongside the tri-service Strategic Forces Command.

Demonstrating its strong commitment to jointness, the Navy waived its claim to the post of C-in-C FENC, offering it, and the Fortress A&N as a crucible for India's bold new experiment. This offer having been accepted, on October 8, 2001, all military assets in the A&N islands — including the Coast Guard — were placed under the newly created C-in-C Andaman & Nicobar Command (CINCAN), reporting directly to the CDS/COSC.

As the first CINCAN, I watched with concern the initial inter-service tensions amongst my staff, rooted in mental blocks and mutual suspicion. With time, it was gratifying to see that as we

donned a common (camouflage) uniform, officers began to appreciate and adopt each other's perspectives, procedures and even terminology.

A genuine spirit of jointness emerged spontaneously in every aspect of administration and operations, as the ANC evolved into an efficient, functioning joint-formation, which was to play a sterling role in the 2004 tsunami.

At this juncture, our SE Asian neighbours, increasingly wary of China, expected India to project influence by deploying substantial power-projection capabilities in the islands. Shortly after the ANC was established, Premier Hu Jintao issued his famous warning regarding China's "Malacca dilemma".

Regrettably, the MEA took the view that any significant force build-up in the islands would be perceived by our neighbours as muscle-flexing and advised against it. Thus, despite repeated and fervent appeals from successive CINCANs, the government has, over the past 25 years, refrained from boosting triservice force levels that would have enabled ANC to meet security challenges and to project influence in the region.

As the microcosm of a theatre command, the ANC has fulfilled its unwritten mandate: to build the framework for a unified military formation, test it in practice, develop operating procedures and working rules, and offer a template for replication on a larger scale elsewhere.

Unfortunately, there is no evidence that the ANC model has received serious consideration as an example for emulation or problem-solving, either in the ongoing inter-service wrangling or in seminars where "theaterisation" is discussed.

Finally, a word about the future of the ANC. The term "expeditionary" has lost much of its earlier menacing connotation. Such forces are now essential for safeguarding a nation's vital interests beyond its borders, whether they relate to freedom of navigation, trade, energy or diaspora.

As India's only geographically defined triservice command, the ANC has developed joint planning processes, procedures and command systems that underpin rapid-reaction operations. Provided with the necessary wherewithal, this command is ideally placed to handle the full gamut of maritime roles: military, diplomatic, constabulary and benign.

Moreover, as India's sea-based nuclear deterrent becomes operational, ANC will be the guardian of its secure "maritime bastion" in the Bay of Bengal; extending surveillance, strike and anti-submarine cover.

Should theaterisation happen, there is merit in earmarking the ANC as a standalone, forward maritime outpost, given its unique geography, its role in the region and the proven jointness model it represents.

When politics silences generals



LT GEN SK SAINI (RETD)
FORMER VICE CHIEF OF ARMY STAFF

WHILE civilian control of the military is one of the foundational principles of a democratic state, the recent aggressive actions of US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth presage a destructive fracture in the American civil-military equation. However, India's experience offers a compelling counterpoint.

On September 30, at the Marine Corps Base in Quantico, Hegseth announced a sweeping 20% cut in senior military ranks, besides other structural changes like creating an autonomous warfare command.

The address also contained highly hostile criticism of the previous military leadership and the Pentagon bureaucracy. His language was particularly offensive, unparliamentary and inappropriate: "We are no longer the woke department or the weak department. Simple translation of that: no fannies, no trannies, no beards, no weirdos, no wimps, no radicals. Just warriors. Just tough, ready, committed troops." He also stated: "The ideological clowns are out. The patriotic cowboys are in, with testosterone testing on top. Diversity is not our strength. Unity is our strength."

It was not the first such episode. In September 2025, when addressing

the military's senior leadership, Hegseth sharply criticised senior officers, referring to "fat generals" and telling officers who did not support his agenda that they should resign.

The announcement of a further 20% reduction in positions for generals and admirals is the latest in a series of sweeping changes implemented in the US military establishment. Reuters reported that the plan would reduce billets for one-to four-star officers, with some positions eliminated and others downgraded. It follows an earlier initiative to reduce senior leadership positions by at least 10%. In fact, the proposal to reduce billets for senior ranks predates Hegseth.

Importantly, the issue is not whether the number of senior officers can ever be reduced. It is how such decisions are reached, whose professional advice is considered and whether dissenting military assessments remain possible without career consequences. That distinction is crucial. The US system was deliberately anchored to preserve professional military advice while ensuring civilian supremacy. Under the Goldwater-Nichols framework, the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff is the principal military adviser to the President and Secretary of

Defence. The Chairman is required to consult the other service chiefs and combatant commanders and, where appropriate, present the range of military advice and options. Their duty is not to agree with the political leadership. Their duty is to provide their best professional military judgment, including when that judgment is inconvenient.

Civilian control, therefore, does not mean exclusion of military advice. It means that the civilian authority makes the final decision after receiving professional advice. While a non-military secretary is constitutionally the head of the Department of Defence, the erosion of trust and the dismissal of military wisdom risk turning strategic decisions into political gambits with the lives of service members and the safety of the nation at stake. It does not, however, mean that political leaders should substitute political judgment for professional military advice. The strength of the civil-military relationship lies in the separation of roles with elected leaders determining national objectives and professional military leaders advising on the application of military power, resources, time and risks involved.

Recent developments in the US raise important questions about whether this balance is being adequately maintained. While streamlining a bloated bureaucracy is a legitimate goal, the manner and context of these cuts are deeply troubling. Reports indicate that Hegseth has already driven out or blocked the promotions of dozens of officers, a disproportionate number of whom are black or female without offering clear explanations.

For full article, go to www.tribuneindia.com/opinion

The strength of the
civil-military
relationship lies in
the separation of roles.

Liberate the gurdwaras



COL AVTAR SINGH HIRA (RETD)
JAGO PUNJAB PARTY

ANANDPUR SAHIB is the birthplace of the Khalsa, where Guru Gobind Singh created a community pledged to justice and to protecting the weak. That a woman now alleges she was raped and confined on the premises of this shrine's complex should disturb every Sikh and every Punjabi.

The FIR was registered at Anandpur Sahib police station on August 21 under BNS Sections 64, 127(2) and 351(2), covering rape, wrongful confinement and criminal intimidation. It names Amarjit Singh Chawla, SGPC member and senior Akali Dal vice-president, as the accused. The complainant is from Sangrur district and the alleged incidents span February 27 to August 19. Chawla has denied everything, calling the case false and a conspiracy, and says he will prove his innocence in court. He is entitled to the presumption of innocence and a fair trial.

But, the law's presumption cannot excuse institutional failure. The questions here go well beyond one man. Why did the system stay silent? Nearly a month after the FIR, no arrest had been made, and the investigation was entrusted to an assistant sub-inspector. Senior Ropar police officers stayed silent even after the FIR. If the accused were an ordinary citizen, would the response have

been so muted? Sources also say that Chawla left for Canada a week before the FIR. The courts and police must ensure that no person can use distance or status to avoid the law.

The complainant's allegation that she approached the SGPC, Akali Dal and Akal Takht leadership without redress must be examined. We have not independently verified that claim. It demands a transparent answer. Punjab needs a public account of who was told, when and what was done. Only after the FIR did the SGPC suspend two employees named in the complaint and order an inquiry. Recently, the five high priests excommunicated Chawla and the Additional Head Granthi of the Akal Takht. These steps are welcome, but they are reactive. Institutions that respond only after police intervention or media attention have already fallen short of their duty of care.

The deeper rot is structural. The SGPC House has a five-year term. Yet the last election was held in 2011. An unelected body controlling the gurdwaras is a betrayal of the Sikh Gurdwaras Act, which promised a management accountable to the *sangat*. Without elections, committee members are not answerable to the devotees whose donations, made in faith, fill the *golak*. Appointments

and inquiries follow the convenience of the ruling faction rather than the rules of *maryada*. Sikhs and Punjabis have every right to ask whether gurdwara funds are being managed for the Panth or for a political party. That question can only be answered through independent audits and open books.

The blame is shared. The Centre has the authority to notify elections and has not done so for over a decade. The SGPC leadership is enjoying an indefinite tenure. The Akali Dal, which has long treated the SGPC as an extension of its political machinery, has blurred the line between religious trust and party interest. The *Panth* has been watching these three institutions each pointing at the others.

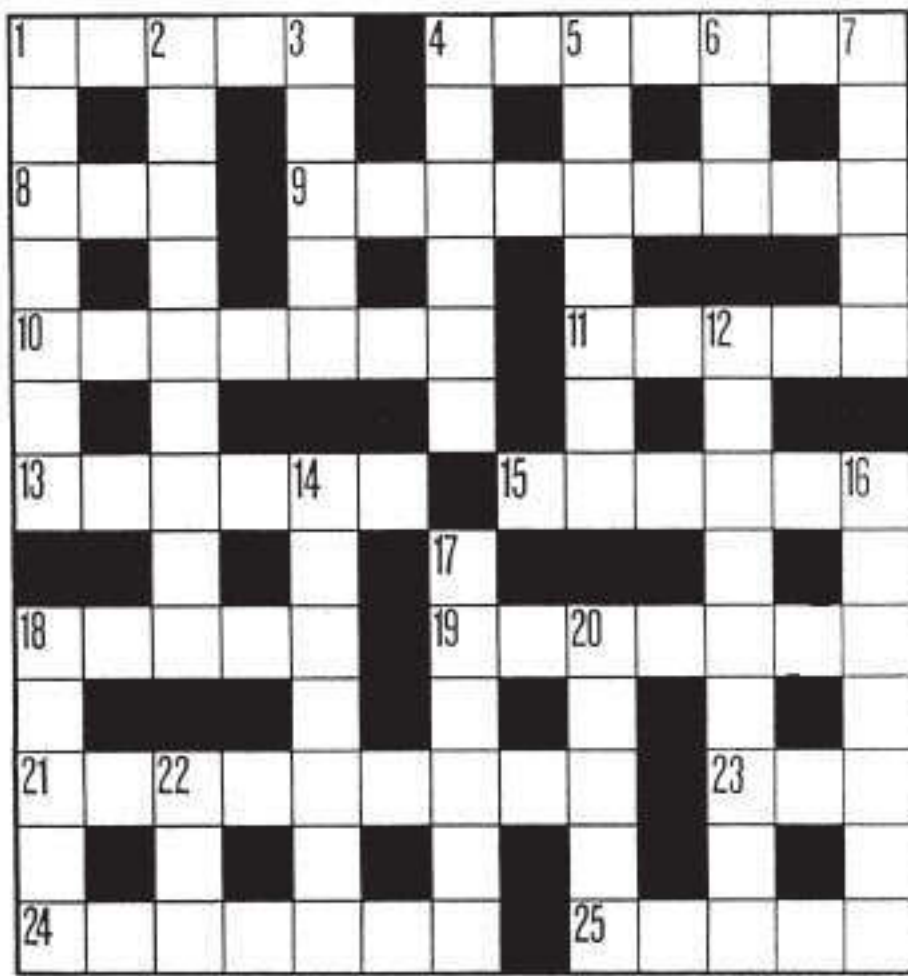
In the early twentieth century, hereditary *mahants* controlled the historic gurdwaras and treated them as private property. The Gurdwara Reform Movement, at enormous cost in lives and imprisonment, freed the gurdwaras and gave rise to the SGPC and the Akali movement. Those sacrifices were made so that gurdwaras would belong to the *sangat*. Today, a new form of *mahant* rule, based on political patronage and the absence of elections, has taken hold. The sons and daughters of Punjab must complete the unfinished work of that reform.

The Punjab Bachao Morcha and Jago Punjab Party stand with the demand for a democratic, transparent and accountable gurdwara administration. Restoring the honour of Anandpur Sahib requires a fair trial and the return of the gurdwaras to the *Panth* through free and fair elections.

For full article, go to www.tribuneindia.com/opinion

Today, a new form of
mahant rule has
taken hold.

QUICK CROSSWORD



ACROSS

- 1 16th century English diarist (5)
- 4 Break up (7)
- 8 Large cask (3)
- 9 To a sickening extent (2,7)
- 10 Mortified (7)
- 11 Close friend (5)
- 13 Hang around (6)
- 15 Actually (2,4)
- 18 Contemptible (5)
- 19 Daydreaming (7)
- 21 Assembled for business (2,7)
- 23 By way of (3)
- 24 At a future time (7)
- 25 A sortie by troops (5)

Saturday's Solution

Across: 1 Port of call, 8 Siren, 9 Thinker, 10 Admiral, 11 Bonus, 12 Lunacy, 14 Benign, 17 Plant, 19 Trapped, 21 Courage, 22 Glory, 23 Take to task.

Down: 2 Oarsman, 3 Tenor, 4 Futile, 5 Amiable, 6 Liken, 7 Present-day, 8 Snail's pace, 13 Cut back, 15 Impious, 16 At best, 18 Adult, 20 Angst.

DOWN

- 1 An unsuspected hazard (7)
- 2 Culminating point of a joke (5,4)
- 3 Cluster of bees (5)
- 4 Lay bare (6)
- 5 Very small quantity (7)
- 6 Unreturnable tennis service (3)
- 7 Ventriloquist's doll (5)
- 12 Having reached destination (2,7)
- 14 Open to the elements (7)
- 16 Curative treatment (7)
- 17 Intellectually clever (6)
- 18 Small change (5)
- 20 Roman goddess of love (5)
- 22 Total amount (3)

SU DO KU

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		8	2	9	4	
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	1					8
3	7		9	6		4
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		1	3	5		6
7	9					1

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SUNSET: SUNRISE:	MONDAY TUESDAY	18:03 HRS 06:19 HRS
CITY	MAX	MIN
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New Delhi	36	23
Amritsar	34	24
Bathinda	35	22
Jalandhar	33	24
Ludhiana	33	24
Bhiwani	36	23
Hisar	37	23
Sirsa	34	24
Dharamsala	29	16
Manali	26	13
Shimla	25	16
Srinagar	32	12
Jammu	34	23
Kargil	26	05
Leh	21	03
Dehradun	33	21
Mussoorie	20	15

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Shimla, Kullu most exposed to landslide risk, reveals AI study

35% of buildings in Shimla, 30% in Kullu located in vulnerable zones

DIPENDER MANTA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

MANDI, OCTOBER 4
An artificial intelligence-based assessment by researchers at the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Mandi, has revealed sharp differences in the exposure of buildings to landslide-prone areas across Himachal Pradesh, with Shimla and Kullu emerging among the districts with the highest levels of built-up exposure.

The study found that around 35 per cent of buildings in Shimla and 30 per cent in Kullu are located within areas identified as susceptible to landslides. Mandi recorded building exposure of about 22 per cent, followed by Solan at 21 per cent.

The assessment was carried out by IIT-Mandi researchers Ankit Singh, Nitesh Dhiman, Kirti Kumar Mahanta and Dericks P Shukla, Professor of Remote Sensing at the School of Civil and Environmental Engineering.

The researchers used machine-learning-based Landslide Susceptibility Maps (LSMs) to assess the likelihood of landslides across the state. Three artificial intelligence models —



Densely settled hill districts are particularly vulnerable as urban expansion encroaches on steep and geologically sensitive slopes.

Random Forest (RF), Support Vector Machine (SVM) and Multilayer Perceptron (MLP) — were employed to classify areas according to their varying levels of landslide susceptibility. The results were then integrated with building location data to determine the extent of exposure.

The findings assume particular importance in densely settled hill districts, where urban expansion and infrastructure development frequently extend onto steep and geologically sensitive slopes. Construction in or near unstable terrain can increase the potential impact of landslides on people, buildings

and critical infrastructure.

The researchers noted that combining building data with susceptibility maps offers a more practical picture of risk than susceptibility mapping alone. While a conventional susceptibility map identifies areas where landslides are more likely, overlaying it with building locations helps establish where the hazard could directly affect the built environment.

The assessment also revealed significant variations across the state. More than 90 per cent of buildings in Una, Hamirpur and Lahaul-Spiti were found to be outside the identified land-

slide-risk zones, indicating that the presence of susceptible terrain does not automatically translate into high exposure of buildings.

Interestingly, Kangra and Kinnaur, despite experiencing frequent landslides, recorded comparatively lower building exposure. About 5 per cent of buildings in Kangra and 14 per cent in Kinnaur were identified as exposed. The researchers suggested that many landslides in these districts occur in non-built-up or sparsely populated areas.

The study could have important implications for urban planning and disaster management. District-level exposure assessments can help authorities prioritise slope-stability measures, land-use regulation, preparedness and targeted mitigation.

With landslides posing a persistent challenge to development in the Himalayan region, the researchers said integrating AI-driven susceptibility modeling with building datasets could help shift disaster-risk assessment from simply identifying hazardous terrain to determining where communities and infrastructure are most likely to be affected.

Monsoon losses ₹3,232 crore this year, more showers on way

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

SHIMLA, OCTOBER 4
Himachal Pradesh suffered losses estimated at Rs 3,231.87 crore due to torrential rains during this year's monsoon, according to the Department of Revenue. While the damage remains substantial, it is lower than the Rs 4,881 crore loss reported during the monsoon last year.

The Public Works Department (PWD) bore the brunt of the damage, reporting losses of Rs 2,744.67 crore. The Jal Shakti Vibhag suffered losses of Rs 393.96 crore, while the Power Department reported damage worth Rs 21.5 crore. The horticulture sector suffered losses estimated at Rs 9.19 crore, while agriculture recorded damage of Rs 1.42 crore.

The monsoon also took a heavy human toll. As many as 385 persons lost their lives in the state during the season. Of these, 229 deaths were attributed to road accidents, while 156 occurred due to natural disasters, including flashfloods and landslides. Around 153 houses were completely damaged across the state due to heavy rains.

The state, however, is bracing for another spell of unsettled weather from October 6, with the Meteorological Centre issuing yellow alerts. Light to moderate rain

Yellow alert from tomorrow as state faces another spell of thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds



The Public Works Department bore the brunt of the damage, reporting losses of ₹2,744.67 crore. TRIBUNE FILE

accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds is likely at isolated places until October 10.

The weather system is also expected to bring a drop in temperatures. Minimum temperatures may fall by 2°C to 3°C, while maximum temperatures are likely to decline by 2°C to 5°C during the period.

The state experienced largely dry weather during the past 24 hours, with most areas recording bright sunshine. Minimum temperatures remained 2°C to 3°C above normal, ranging from 4°C to 23°C, while maximum

temperatures were 2°C to 4°C above normal and ranged between 19°C and 34°C.

Shimla recorded a maximum temperature of 24.9°C, while Dharamsala and Manali registered 28°C and 25.2°C, respectively. Solan recorded 27.4°C, Kangra 31.5°C, Mandi and Sundernagar 31.4°C each, Bhuntar 32.4°C and Bilaspur 32°C. Kalpa recorded 24.6°C, Nahan 30.7°C and Kufri 19°C.

Una recorded the state's highest maximum temperature at 34.8°C, while Tabo in Lahaul and Spiti recorded the lowest minimum temperature at 4.4°C.

Weather plays spoilsport at Bir-Billing

PALAMPUR, OCTOBER 4

Bad weather played spoilsport at the world-famous Bir-Billing paragliding site on Saturday, leaving scores of tourists disappointed as flights were suspended for most of the day.

The morning began with clear skies and sunshine, allowing paragliding operations to start normally. However, weather conditions deteriorated quickly, with thick clouds and dense fog enveloping the valley. For safety reasons, no flights were operated after 11 am. Pilots and tourists waited for several hours in the hope that conditions would improve, but persistent cloud cover dashed their expectations.

Tourists who had travelled from different parts of the country were particularly disappointed. Gujarat tourist Shyam Sundar and Delhi visitors Neha and Amisha said they had travelled to Bir-Billing specifically to experience paragliding but were forced to return without getting a chance to fly.

Adding to their woes was heavy traffic on the narrow road leading to the Billing valley. Long queues of vehicles stretched along the route, with several motorists reportedly stranded for hours. Later in the evening, local pilots and taxi drivers stepped in to help clear the congestion, providing some relief to tourists and motorists. — OC

600 cops, tight traffic plan for President's Manali visit

ABHINAV VASHISHT

KULLU, OCTOBER 4

President Droupadi Murmu's visit to Himachal Pradesh from October 6 to 8 will bring temporary traffic restrictions and curbs on tourist movement in and around Manali, Atal Tunnel and the Hadimba Devi Temple, with the district administration putting in place an elaborate security and traffic management plan.

The President will arrive in Manali on the evening of October 6 after visiting AIIMS-Bilaspur. During her stay, she is scheduled to visit Atal Tunnel and Mata Hadimba Temple. Her earlier visit to the Atal Tunnel, planned for April 29, had been cancelled due to adverse weather.

Kullu Deputy Commissioner Amit Kumar Sharma said heavy vehicles heading towards Manali would be stopped at the NGT barrier at 11.30am on October 6. Movement would be halted above the Defence Geoinformatics Research Establishment (DGRE) at Bahang near the Manali main gate from 12.15 pm. From 8 pm, heavy vehicles travelling between Manali and Lahaul-Spiti would be diverted through Aloo Ground until 1 pm on October 7.

On October 7, traffic regulation will begin at the Sissu Atal Tunnel north portal

bridge at 6.30 am. Vehicles travelling from Lahaul-Spiti towards Manali will be allowed only through Rohtang Pass, while trucks and heavy vehicles bound for Lahaul-Spiti will be stopped at the NGT barrier from 7 am.

From 8 am, police nakas will operate at Log Hut Chowk, Manalsu Mour, Main Chowk Ram Bagh, Mission Hospital, Old Bridge, Bhoothnath Chowk, Vashisht Road, Nehru Kund Bridge, Palchan Bridge and Palchan Chowk. Normal traffic will resume around five minutes after the presidential convoy crosses Palchan, with similar restrictions during the return journey.

The President's visit to Hadimba Temple between 3 pm and 5 pm will trigger additional traffic controls at Ram Bagh Chowk, Ghatotkach Chowk, Manalsu and Log Hut Chowk.

On October 8, the President will leave the Manali Circuit House for the DGRE helipad at 10 am. Heavy vehicles will be stopped at the NGT barrier from 7 am and barred beyond Palchan and Atal Tunnel nakas. Barricading will begin at 9 am at several locations.

Manali has been divided into nine sectors, with 600 police personnel deployed. SP Abishek Sekar urged residents and drivers to follow the traffic plan.

NZ offers help to boost apple yield in state

SHIMLA, OCTOBER 4

New Zealand is set to extend technical support to Himachal Pradesh to improve apple productivity and quality, with experts highlighting the wide gap between the state's average yields and those achieved in advanced apple-growing regions.

Danielle Adsett, Chief Executive Officer of New Zealand's Apple and Pear Industry, said Himachal's average apple productivity was around 5-6 metric tonnes (MT) per hectare, compared with about 57 MT in New Zealand. In newer, advanced orchards, yields can reach up to 80 MT per hectare, she said.

Adsett, along with her colleague Lachlan McKay, recently visited apple orchards in Kotgarh to assess ground realities and interact with growers. She said Himachal had considerable scope to raise productivity, with yields potentially reaching 30-40 MT per hectare. — TNS

Bronze won, Olympics next: Seema won't slow down

Chamba's Asian Games medallist vows to return to training after emotional homecoming

NARESH THAKUR
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

DHARAMSALA, OCTOBER 4

Asian Games 10,000m bronze medallist Seema received a rousing welcome in her home district on Sunday after returning from Nagoya, Japan, where she secured a historic podium finish.

Hailing from remote Retta village in Chamba, Seema was felicitated at Rising Star Public School, where school chairman Dr Sanjeev Suri and vice-principal Deepti honoured the athlete. Municipal Council president Bhuvaneshwari Gulati and District Sports Officer Rupesh Kumar also felicitated her and described her achievement as a moment of pride for Chamba.

Speaking at the reception, an emotional Seema recalled the sacrifices and hardships that shaped her journey to the international podium, particularly the long periods of separation from her mother.

"It has been a year since I last saw my mother. She



Asian Games 10,000m bronze medallist Seema receives a rousing welcome in Chamba. MANI VERMA/PTI

keeps asking me to come home, but it is extremely difficult to interrupt my training," she said, adding that she has often spent years away from home while pursuing her sporting goals.

Thanking the people of Chamba for organising the reception, Seema said the warmth and affection she received had given her fresh motivation to work harder. She also spoke candidly

about the social restrictions she encountered when she began pursuing athletics. Recalling her hostel trials in 2015, she said girls from her area were often discouraged from leaving home to pursue opportunities outside the region.

"There were restrictions on me, not from my mother but from society," she said. Her journey, she added, had helped change perceptions and encouraged more girls from

her village to pursue education and careers beyond the region.

Urging youngsters to create their own identity, Seema said they should give their best in whichever field they choose. "You don't need to become like anyone else. Work so hard that your name remains in the pages of history," she said.

For Seema, the Asian Games bronze is only another milestone. She has set her sights on the Asian Championships,



Rave parties make a discreet comeback in upper Dharamsala

From forest clearings to hostels and cafes, organisers shift gatherings indoors and out of public view



NARESH THAKUR
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

DHARAMSALA, OCTOBER 4

While Kullu and Parvati valley have been grabbing headlines over rave parties following the High Court crackdown, a similar trend appears to be quietly re-emerging in the upper Dharamsala region, albeit in a more discreet form.

Instead of the open-air, forest-based parties once associated with Dharamkot and Bhagsu Nag, organisers are increasingly shifting to indoor venues and closed networks to keep such gatherings away from public view.

In the past two months, Kangra police have busted two alleged rave parties in the upper Dharamsala belt, recovering drugs and liquor. The investigations have also indicated that the events were allegedly promoted through social media platforms and closed online groups.

The latest raid took place during the intervening night

of September 13 and 14 at a backpacker hostel in upper Dharamkot. Acting on a tip-off, a police team headed by DIG (North) Soumya Sambasivan raided the premises in the early hours and recovered small quantities of four types of contraband — chitta, opium, charas and cannabis.

The raid followed another action on August 23, when Kangra police, again led by Sambasivan, busted an alleged rave party at a cafe in upper Bhagsu. Contraband and liquor were recovered from the premises. Investigators also found that the event had allegedly been advertised through social media and closed online groups.

The two cases point to a shift in the character of rave-party culture in upper Dharamsala. The gatherings are no longer necessarily large, open events held deep inside forests and accessible through word of mouth. Instead, organisers appear to be opting for smaller indoor events where entry can be controlled and information about the venue shared only with selected participants.



A poster of a rave party busted by the Kangra police in September.

This marks a departure from the rave culture associated with upper Dharamsala villages during the 2000-2010 decade. Dharamkot, Bhagsu Nag and adjoining far-flung villages in Shahpur subdivision had emerged as popular destinations for international backpackers, particularly

Israelis and Europeans, and developed a reputation for their alternative lifestyle and psychedelic music culture.

During that period, electronic music parties were often associated with full-moon nights, forest clearings and secluded mountain locations. Parties could continue

through the night, away from the main settlements, with organisers relying on word of mouth, messages and informal networks to keep locations from becoming widely known.

The surrounding forests and rugged terrain provided natural cover. With restrictions on loud music at night and growing complaints from residents, organisers often moved away from established settlements to secluded locations. What began as an alternative music and backpacker culture gradually attracted greater police attention as allegations of drug use and illegal liquor consumption became associated with some of these gatherings.

By the latter part of the decade, repeated police interventions and heightened scrutiny had pushed the open-air rave culture into decline. Raids, restrictions on late-night music and growing awareness of drug networks operating around some parties made it increasingly difficult to organise large gatherings in the open.

Yet, the latest cases suggest that the culture may not have

disappeared completely but changed its methods.

The forests that once provided anonymity are now being replaced by closed premises, while flyers and word-of-mouth networks have given way to social media accounts, private groups and digital invitations. For the police, this creates a different challenge — identifying a gathering before it takes place rather than responding to a visibly large crowd in a remote forest.

The renewed activity comes at a time when the state police are intensifying their campaign against drugs and authorities are keeping a closer watch on rave-party culture in Himachal's tourist destinations. With Kullu and Parvati Valley already under heightened scrutiny, the recent Kangra raids indicate that upper Dharamsala, too, remains on the radar.

For a region that once became synonymous with full-moon forest parties, the emerging trend is markedly different — quieter, smaller and more difficult to detect, but still drawing the attention of law enforcement.

TENDER NOTICE
OPEN TENDER NOTICE: CATERING CONTRACT KHETARPAL OFFICERS' MESS & INSTITUTE AND SEPTA CHANDIMANDIR
1. Sealed tenders are invited from well established caterers with experience and repute for providing Catering Services at Khetarpal Officers' Mess & Institute (KOM&I) including Sambandh and Shivalik Environment Park & Training Area (SEPTA) at Chandimandir Military Station.
2. Bids will be submitted separately for Khetarpal Officer's Mess & Institute (KOM&I) and Shivalik Environment Park & Training Area (SEPTA). Bidders may apply for one or both contracts. The bidders will be selected by both institute on their specific requirements separately.
3. Period of Contract: **01 Dec 2026 to 30 Nov 2027.**
4. Selected bidders shall operate all existing restaurants, cafes, party halls, daily catering at KOM&I and would automatically considered empanelled for catering at Sambandh Complex.
5. Tender documents for both contracts will be available at KOM&I office on payment of Rs. 1000/- each (Non refundable) from 05 Oct 2026 onwards during office hours.
6. Pre bid meeting: KOM&I on 08 Oct 2026 at 1100hrs, for clarification of any issues by bidders.
7. Bidders to deposit separate sealed envelopes for technical bids and commercial bids. The envelopes will be marked as such with bidders company name mentioned. In case any bidder is applying for both institutes, separate envelopes for KOM&I and SEPTA be submitted.
8. Tenders deposit: KOM&I office 15-16 Oct 2026 between 1000hrs to 1500hrs noon alongwith EMD of Rs. 1,00,000/- (One Lakh) separately for KOM&I and SEPTA to be placed in technical bid envelope drawn in favour of KOM&I Chandimandir (refundable for unsuccessful bids).
9. Management of KOM&I reserves the right to accept or reject any or all tenders without assigning any reasons whatsoever.
10. Bids not meeting the terms and conditions mentioned in the tender form will be liable for disqualification/ rejection.
11. Contact details: 0172-2922290 and 8146418504. Email: komichandimandir@gmail.com.

Management Committee
Khetarpal Officers' Mess & Institute
Chandimandir Cantt
Panchkula (Haryana)

Place: Chandimandir
Dated: 05 Oct 2026

IN BRIEF

Pak prisoner dies by suicide in Jammu jail

Jammu: A 36-year-old Pakistani undertrial prisoner died of suspected suicide at the high-security Central Jail here on Sunday, officials said. Shahid Imran, a resident of Sargodha in Pakistan's Punjab province, was arrested along the International Border in the Makwal sector of Jammu in October 2024 and lodged in Kot Bhalwal jail, they said. The prisoner who was suffering from a mental disorder was found unconscious in his cell, following which a preliminary inquiry suggested that he had attempted suicide, officials said. He was immediately shifted to Government Medical College hospital in Jammu, where doctors declared him dead. Hospital sources said the deceased had a ligature mark around his neck. The body was shifted to the mortuary for post-mortem, officials said. oc

45-yr-old soldier found hanging inside camp

Jammu: A 45-year-old soldier allegedly died by suicide after hanging himself in an Army camp here on Sunday, officials said. Naik Wagh Ambades, a resident of Maharashtra, was found hanging in a shed at Sun-jwan camp in Channi Himmat area here, they said. The body was shifted to Government Medical College Hospital for postmortem and other legal formalities, officials said. The motive behind the alleged suicide was not immediately known, they said, adding that police have started inquest proceedings in connection with the incident. pti

Army man held with drugs at airport

Srinagar: Security forces arrested an Army man at the drop gate of Srinagar International Airport after some contraband substance was recovered from his baggage, officials said on Sunday. Police and CRPF personnel apprehended the Army man on Saturday as they recovered poppy straw and cannabis-like substance from his possession, the officials said. The banned substances recovered included 213 grams of poppy straw and 69 grams of cannabis-like substance. A case under relevant sections of the law have been registered and investigation set into motion, they added. pti

Security forces step up vigil amid reports of terrorist movement in Jammu region

Preparedness reviewed as search ops continue in Rajouri, Udhampur and other areas

ARJUN SHARMA

JAMMU, OCTOBER 4 Security forces have intensified search operations and stepped up surveillance across parts of Jammu and Kashmir amid reports of suspected movement of Pakistani terrorists in forested areas of the Jammu region. Meanwhile, senior officers of the Army and police are reviewing operational preparedness, intelligence-sharing and security arrangements in sensitive areas including the Line of Control (LoC).

On Sunday, joint teams of the Army and police launched multiple search operations in Rajouri and Udhampur districts following intelligence inputs and reports from local residents about the presence of suspected terrorists.

In Rajouri's Sunderbani sector, three unidentified suspects allegedly abducted a villager, Anil Sudan, near Upper Lardia late on Saturday night. Officials said Sudan was later released after the suspects reportedly used him as a guide to reach the Dua Khad forest area.

Following information provided by local residents, security forces launched a



Special Operations Group of the Jammu and Kashmir Police with a sniffer dog in action during a search operation as part of security measures in Akhnoor, Jammu, on Sunday. ANI

massive cordon-and-search operation to track the suspects. However, no contact had been established with them till Sunday evening.

Another operation was launched in the Mandugala Dhok forest area of Rajouri after locals reported the movement of two suspected terrorists. Security personnel also conducted searches in Chigli Keya village of Udhampur district.

Meanwhile, counter-terror operations have been intensified across the Union Terri-

tory following recent successes against terrorist groups. Security agencies are maintaining pressure on militants believed to be hiding in forest belts and mountainous areas.

In Srinagar, Lt Gen Pratik Sharma, General Officer Commanding-in-Chief (GOC-in-C), Northern Command, chaired a high-level security review meeting with key stakeholders to assess the prevailing security situation, operational preparedness and inter-agency coordination.

According to officials, the Army Commander emphasised greater synergy among security agencies, real-time intelligence sharing and integrated planning to strengthen operational readiness and improve the effectiveness of joint operations.

Separately, Lt Gen Mohit Seth, General Officer Commanding of the Nagrota-based White Knight Corps, visited forward posts along the Line of Control in the Poonch and Krishna Ghati

sectors to review operational preparedness and counter-infiltration measures.

He was briefed on the prevailing security environment, surveillance mechanisms and ongoing efforts to enhance operational effectiveness. During the visit, he urged troops to maintain the highest standards of vigilance and operational readiness.

Senior police officers have also undertaken security reviews across the region. Deputy Inspector General of Police Sargun Shukla visited Kishtwar and chaired a meeting to review the security and crime situation in the district. Officials briefed her on terrorism-related challenges, counter-terror preparedness and ongoing operations.

Earlier, Inspector General of Police, Jammu Zone, Tejinder Singh, visited Kathua and directed officers to strengthen the security grid in view of the evolving security scenario and upcoming festive season.

Officials said security agencies remain on high alert and are continuing coordinated operations to prevent infiltration attempts and disrupt terrorist activities.

Dy CM pulls up officials over delay in projects

JAMMU, OCTOBER 4 Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Choudhary on Sunday reviewed the progress of two major long-span bridges being constructed under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY) on the T01-Dhalote via Talour road in Samba district and directed officials to expedite the works while ensuring strict quality standards.

During an inspection of the projects in Sumb block, the Deputy Chief Minister expressed concern over the slow pace of construction and asked the concerned officers

to identify the reasons behind the delays and take immediate corrective measures.

He stressed that accountability should be fixed for any undue delay and directed the executing agency and officers concerned to ensure time-bound completion of the projects through close monitoring at every stage.

Choudhary also ordered a comprehensive quality assessment of the ongoing works, emphasising that construction must strictly adhere to approved designs, technical specifications and prescribed engineering standards. — OC

CAG flags massive CSR spending shortfall in J&K PSEs

ARJUN SHARMA

JAMMU, OCTOBER 4 The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) has flagged significant underutilisation of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) funds by Jammu and Kashmir's public sector enterprises (PSEs), revealing that only Rs 3.05 crore was spent against an allocation of Rs 27.42 crore during 2022-23.

According to the audit report, public sector enterprises in the Union Territory left Rs 24.37 crore unspent, highlighting major gaps between mandated allocations and actual expenditure, besides delays in transfer-

ring unspent funds to designated government accounts.

Under Section 135(5) of the Companies Act, eligible companies are required to spend at least two per cent of their average net profits from the preceding three financial years on CSR activities.

The report noted that of the nine Union Territory PSEs examined, seven were required to undertake CSR expenditure amounting to Rs 12.64 crore. The remaining two enterprises were exempt because they had incurred losses during the preceding three financial years.

Audit findings showed that only three of the seven

Only ₹3.05 crore spent against ₹27.42 crore allocated in 2022-23

eligible PSEs spent funds on CSR activities. While a total allocation of Rs 27.42 crore had been made, including Rs 16.34 crore carried forward from previous years, actual expenditure stood at only Rs 3.05 crore.

Among the enterprises reviewed, Jammu and Kashmir Bank Limited fully utilised its allocated CSR funds during 2022-23. In contrast, the Jammu and Kashmir State Power Development Corporation Limit-

NHRC seeks probe into disability cases linked to toxic cough syrup

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAMMU, OCTOBER 4 The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) has directed the Jammu and Kashmir authorities to conduct an inquiry into the permanent disabilities allegedly suffered by four children after consuming a cough syrup in Udhampur district during 2019-20.

The direction came in response to a complaint filed by social activist Sukesh C Khajuria, who sought adequate compensation, medical care and rehabilitation for the affected children.

In its communication to the Chief Secretary, the NHRC stated that the complaint should be forwarded to the competent authority for appropriate action in accordance with law. "The authority concerned is directed to take appropriate action after enquiry, associating the complainant and victims, inform them of the action taken and submit a report to the Commission within four weeks," the Commission said.

In his complaint, Khajuria argued that the four surviving children, whose lives were permanently altered by the incident, deserve justice and long-term support. He described the tragedy as part of a larger national problem involving fatalities allegedly

linked to spurious cough syrups contaminated with Diethylene Glycol (DEG), a toxic industrial solvent.

Referring to the Jammu incident of 2019-20, Khajuria alleged that 14 children had lost their lives after consuming the contaminated syrup. He said testing by the Regional Drug Testing Laboratory (RDTL), Chandigarh, had reportedly confirmed the presence of 34.24 per cent w/v DEG in the medicine.

The activist alleged that despite the seriousness of the tragedy, the response of the then drug regulatory authorities remained inadequate. He claimed that the matter gained attention only after intervention by the NHRC, following which the government was directed to provide Rs 3 lakh each to the next of kin of the deceased children.

According to the complaint, the High Court and the Supreme Court subsequently upheld the NHRC's recommendation, recognising the State's vicarious liability in the matter.

Khajuria stated four surviving children from Ramnagar tehsil of Udhampur, who were left with permanent disabilities and possess disability certificates issued by the Chief Medical Officer, Udhampur, have yet to receive compensation or rehabilitative support.

Israeli PM invites Smit to light flame on I-Day

links to Australia and how he came to be part of the crew of a flydubai flight bound for Tel Aviv, as the UAE-led probe examines Hamam al-Hammami's motives and connections, according to media reports.

The Australian Federal Police said a counter-terrorism team was investigating the man's links to Australia, the Australian Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) reported on Sunday.

The Victorian Joint Counter Terrorism Team, comprising the Australian Federal Police, Victoria Police and the Australian Security Intelligence Organisation, is conducting the Australian investigation, the Australian Federal Police told ABC and the BBC.

Sources familiar with the case told Australian media that the co-pilot was issued a student visa in 2014 and stud-

ied in Australia between 2015 and 2017 before leaving the country. His visa was cancelled in 2019, the ABC reported, adding that the cancellation was not on character grounds but because he was no longer enrolled in a course and therefore no longer eligible for a student visa.

The UAE said on Saturday that its probe had revealed the co-pilot attempted to carry out a "terrorist act".

UAE Attorney General Hamad Saif Al Shamsi said the co-pilot attacked the captain inside the flight deck with a crash axe and attempted to take control of the aircraft, the state-run WAM news agency reported.

He said investigations were continuing to establish the full circumstances, motives and any links related to the incident.

The co-pilot has been iden-

tified by multiple media outlets as Hamam al-Hammami, an Omani national, although his identity has not been officially confirmed.

The Wall Street Journal reported that al-Hammami had previously been barred from flying in Oman over concerns about his radical ideological views.

CNN, citing sources and an Israeli official, reported that he was removed from flight training because of concerns over his radical views and was subsequently given another role at Oman's national airline.

News reports citing sources said he had been working for flydubai for about eight months. It was not immediately clear to what extent he was vetted before being hired by the UAE-based airline flydubai.

Royal Air Maroc, Moroc-

co's national carrier, told AP news agency that al-Hammami completed a three-month theoretical training period with the airline in 2025 as part of its pre-employment process, but his application was not selected for employment.

Al-Hammami completed a three-year distance-learning course in aviation management at Buckinghamshire New University in the UK and graduated in 2023, the BBC reported, quoting the university. The university said he did not undergo any pilot training at the institution.

The Israeli official also told CNN that several Israeli agencies, including Shin Bet, Mossad, the military and the Transportation Ministry, were investigating how the Omani pilot came to be part of the flight crew.

(With agency inputs)

'BJP's weapon': Uddhav hits out at CEC...

He also invoked Adolf Hitler while criticising what he termed arbitrary rule.

"Hitler was also a dictator, but ultimately he had to shoot himself. A similar situation could arise in this country as well. Those acting arbitrarily should keep this in mind," the Shiv Sena (UBT) chief said.

"We will not rest until he is brought out onto the streets and punished within the framework of the law,"

Uddhav said.

Raj Thackeray demanded that future polls in the country should be conducted through ballot papers. He also called for the cancellation of the SIR exercise in Maharashtra.

The march, dubbed the Virat Garjana Morcha (Grand Roar March), also saw the participation of leaders of the Congress and the Sharad Pawar-led NCP (SP).

The Mumbai protest came

two days after the Cockroach Janta Party staged a "Raj Bharo Andolan" at Shivaji Park against Gyanesh Kumar.

Taking a jibe at the CEC, Raj said, "Gyanesh Kaka, don't loot the vote."

"Our demand is that the entire SIR conducted in Maharashtra should be cancelled. The law says the SIR is undertaken only in emergency situations. Forty to sixty lakh voters were added

during the Assembly elections and power was captured through this. Now, through SIR, two crore people are being removed. Who are these two crore voters," the MNS chief asked.

"I appeal to all political parties to go to Delhi and demand that the SIR be cancelled. Voting machines should be discontinued and elections should be conducted using ballot papers," he said.

Sexual favours, cash showers: Escorts bare details of ₹657-cr IDFC Bank scam

the siphoning of over Rs 60 crore.

In her statement, W-1 told the CBI that dance parties were organised in her name at Jade Manor in Zirakpur and that she was tasked with arranging "the best mujra girls". She alleged that "Pankaj Agarwal sir" frequently pressed Rishi to organise more parties and insisted on bringing in "fresh faces". According to her, two groups of women attended such events, one performing dances and another spending private time with selected guests in rooms at the venue.

W-1 further claimed that

Agarwal would discuss party arrangements in detail over WhatsApp conference calls, including the number of performers and their presentation. She also alleged that guests showered newly issued currency notes on performers and that between Rs 2.5 crore and Rs 3 crore was spent on such gatherings. Over time, she said, Agarwal developed a particular preference for one performer and would specifically seek her presence.

According to W-2, she was once called to Chandigarh for Agarwal. After missing her flight, she was allegedly instructed to travel by taxi. A

suite was booked at Hotel Wyndham, Mohali, where, she claimed, Naresh Kumar Bhuwani, a former superintendent in the Development and Panchayats Department, posted a guard outside the room. She told investigators she received Rs 75,000 for sexual favours.

W-3, a resident of Zirakpur, told the CBI she attended two such parties in November and December 2025 and was paid between Rs 10,000 and Rs 12,000 on each occasion. The women later identified Agarwal after investigators showed them his photograph, the charge sheet states.

Harassed by cops at Jantar Mantar...

Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra questioned the alleged delay in registering an FIR despite protests by journalists and called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah to take cognisance of the allegations.

The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) also demanded an FIR against ACP Vivek Bhagat. CJP co-convenor Saurav Das alleged that the police were shielding the officer and set a deadline of noon on October 5 for the registration of an FIR, warning that journalists and protesters would return to the police station if no action was taken.

The allegations stem from the October 3 protest in the New Delhi area. The police said complaints received by the New Delhi district had been forwarded to the Crime Branch for investigation.

Das said he and CJP leader Ratna Singh approached the police after learning of the allegations and claimed that journalists and protesters had already been demonstrating outside a police station, demanding an FIR.

CPI(M) leader Brinda Karat also sought action against the police personnel named in the complaints. Referring to the allegation against ACP Bhagat, she said the incident

involved a journalist carrying out her professional duties and questioned how a police officer could touch a woman.

"It's not just a woman. She is a journalist doing her duty," Karat said, alleging that the incident amounted to sexual harassment by a senior police officer.

CJP general secretary Aafreen Nawaz condemned the alleged conduct, saying it was a matter of grave concern that a senior official's name had surfaced in connection with molestation allegations. She said the party was monitoring the situation and stood with the protesters in their demand for justice.

Voter deletions...

Indian Constitution did not provide for two classes of citizens — one with voting rights and the other without it.

"Any process which leads to wholesale disenfranchisement of Indian citizens, rendering them citizens without voting rights would be violative of Articles 326 and 14 of the Constitution of India," Justice Bhuyan said.

"One may be a billionaire and another a rickshaw-puller; yet both will have their votes, and the value of their votes would be equal," he said, linking the right to vote to the basic structure doctrine of the Constitution.

"If any process results in disenfranchising millions and millions of Indian citizens making them second-class citizens in their own country in the sense of being citizens without voting rights, such a process is intrinsically arbitrary. No amount of whataboutery can justify it. It strikes at the very heart of the Constitution and I would go to the extent of saying that it is a negation of the constitutional order...." Justice Bhuyan said.

"No authority can do it; no court can condone it. No one is above the Constitution," Justice Bhuyan asserted.

Reacting to the remarks, senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said CEC Gyanesh Kumar has lost all moral right to continue in office. "The courageous jurist has expressed his view that the right to vote is very much part of the basic structure of the Constitution," he said.



BACK TO BOOKS Iraqi students attend the first day of the academic year at a primary school in Najaf. REUTERS

Trump announces new ‘Super Intelligence Force’
WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump has announced the creation of a new federal task force called the “Super Intelligence Force” (SIF) to centralise executive branch policies and lead national efforts in advanced Artificial Intelligence. SpaceX CEO Elon Musk on Sunday posted that he would rename the company’s AI unit to SpaceXS, following US Trump’s push to use the term “Super Intelligence” instead of “Artificial Intelligence”. ANI

Brazil’s Prez vote pits Trump ally against Lula
BRASILIA: Brazilians queued in long lines to vote on Sunday in the first round of a tight election, following a campaign dominated by corruption scandals, economic anxiety and accusations of US meddling. The field of 13 candidates has been dominated by two clear frontrunners — Leftist President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, 80, who is seeking a fourth term, and Senator Flavio Bolsonaro, the 45-year-old son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, who was a political ally of US President Donald Trump. REUTERS

Oppn Nepali Cong’s 15th general convention begins
KATHMANDU: The main Opposition Nepali Congress party’s 15th general convention kicked off in Kathmandu on Sunday. Party’s president Gagan Thapa said Nepal’s political parties must work together to advance the country’s socio-economic transformation alongside democratic changes and deliver tangible results to the people. He said the time had come for the Nepali Congress to transform itself into a party that delivered results instead of merely talking about democracy. PTI

UK-Indian duo face US extradition in cancer drug fraud
LONDON: A British-Indian businessman and his ex-wife are fighting extradition to the US on charges of defrauding American health programmes out of millions of dollars by providing cancer drugs not approved by the country’s federal agency. Sukhi Ghuman and Kiranjit Ghuman, both 48 and now based in the UK, appeared at Westminster Magistrate’s Court in London last week for the extradition hearing. The pair are also being sought to stand trial in the US on separate drug smuggling charges. AP

SC takes suo motu note of row over relocation of Central Secretariat Library

SATYA PRAKASH & MANIKANT MISHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
The Supreme Court has taken suo motu cognisance of a news report on controversy surrounding the proposed relocation of the 135-year-old Central Secretariat Library (CSL) with 8.5 lakh books in the national capital. The SC’s decision comes amid reports that no space has been allocated for the CSL, a little-known but historically significant repository of India’s administrative records and rare books, in the new Central Vista Plan.

135-yr-old facility has over 8.5 lakh books

A Bench of Justice Sanjay Kumar and Justice Sanjeev Sachdeva will on Monday take up the case titled, “In Re: 135-yr-old library, 8.5 lakh books and no room in the Central Vista plan” which was registered on October 3. The ‘office report’ of the top court stated, “It is submitted that the competent authority has been pleased to direct the registration of a fresh Suo Moto Writ Petition. Accordingly, Suo Moto Writ Petition (Civil) No. ... has been registered.” Certain media reports highlighted that the library, currently spread over four floors in Shastri Bhawan since 1969, was facing uncertainty as the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) allotted only two rooms in the Kartavya Bhawan-2 complex. However, the MoHUA has already clarified that the CSL has been provided space in the Kartavya Path redevelopment plan. “Contrary to a few reports, it is clarified that space for the Central Secretariat Library has been provided for in the Kartavya Path redevelopment plan,” the ministry said.

Russian drones hit Indian-owned pharma plant as Merz visits Kyiv

‘Won’t be intimidated’: Germany vows €1-bn aid for Ukraine

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
Six people have been killed and a pharma plant owned by an Indian company has been destroyed in Ukraine following a series of long-range strikes by Russia. Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy accused Russia of purposefully targeting civilian infrastructure. India’s Kusum group’s Pharma plant in Ukraine came under attack by Russian drones, killing one and leaving several injured. The main structure of the pharma plant in Ukraine’s Sumy has been mostly destroyed. The casualties and the number of injured might change, officials said. The Kusum group started in 1994 as a distributor exporting Indian medicines to Ukraine. It is being currently run by Indian national Rajeev Gupta. In 2002, it stopped distributing other firms’ products and began marketing its own brands. It then moved into manufacturing,



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy with German Chancellor Friedrich Merz in Kyiv. REUTERS

LATVIAN PM’S POLL WIN BOOSTS CHANCES FOR PRO-UKRAINE COALITION
■ Latvian lawmakers on Sunday planned to begin negotiations to form a new government following a parliamentary election, in which pro-Ukraine PM Andris Kulbergs’ four-party coalition emerged with 35% of the vote. The election saw a voter turnout above 51%. ■ The United List party is expected to take 42 seats in Parliament, and a multiparty coalition will be needed to govern in a splintered political landscape.

opening plants in India in 2007 and in Sumy in 2009. The attack comes as German Chancellor Friedrich Merz visited Kyiv on Sunday as the sound of air raid sirens and explosions rang out. He announced a new aid package of 1 billion euros for Kyiv.

Show will to extradite Hasina: B’desh minister

DHAKA, OCTOBER 4
Bangladesh on Sunday said it expected India to expedite the extradition of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, saying that besides the legal process, “political intent” was also necessary for her return. The remarks came a day after Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi said India could not give a time-frame for Hasina’s return as Dhaka’s extradition request was being examined

Remarks come day after Indian envoy cited legal steps for her return

through a legal process involving the courts. “There is certainly a legal process involved, but political intent is also necessary,” State Minister for Foreign Affairs Shama Obaed Islam said during a media briefing at her office. — PTI

Imran party begins long march after failed talks

ISLAMABAD, OCTOBER 4
Pakistan’s former PM Imran Khan’s party on Sunday began its long march towards Islamabad from Khyber Pakhtunkhwa following the failure of negotiations with the government. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Sohail Afridi set off from Lakki Marwat’s Gandhi Chowk, saying he would announce his next course of action on Thursday, October 8, when Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf’s convoy reaches Khairabad. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa



Supporters of jailed ex-PM Imran Khan prepare to march demanding his release in Lakki Marwat town of northwestern Pakistan. AP/PTI

President Junaid Akbar Khan was accompanying Afridi, the party said. According to the party, Afridi is leading the march from Gandhi Chowk, where he will join

the participants and proceed towards the next destination. Addressing participants of the party’s long march at Gandhi Chowk in Lakki Marwat, Afridi said his Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf government would not accept any policy detrimental to the interests of the Pashtun people, asserting that only Imran’s “vision and policies” would be followed in the province. He thanked the Pashtuns for their support and said the party’s negotiating committee had gone to Islamabad the previous day to help reduce political tensions. — PTI

Suvendu, Vijay face major test as campaigning for byelection ends

Voting on Oct 6 | 2 seats in Bengal, 2 in TN, 1 in Puducherry; 1 LS seat in Assam

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
The stage is set for bypolls in two Assembly seats of West Bengal, Nandigram and Rejinagar; two seats in Tamil Nadu; one in Puducherry as well as the Nagaon Lok Sabha seat in Assam on October 6, after campaigning ended on Sunday. The results of the bypolls will be announced on October 9. High-voltage multi-cornered contests are expected in both Nandigram and Rejinagar, with the final line-up shaped by withdrawals, candidate arrests, electoral symbol complications, rival Trinamool Congress factions contesting and a dramatic last-minute change of heart by the Mamata Banerjee camp’s Rejinagar nominee. Nandigram is likely to witness a four-cornered contest after the Mamata-led TMC faction extended support to the Congress, with the BJP, Left and the Ritabrata Banerjee-led rebel Trinamool camp pitching their own candidates.



Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay rides a bullock cart during a roadshow ahead of the bypoll in the Dharapuram Assembly constituency. PTI

The Congress’s Nandigram nominee Milan Pradhan was arrested on the basis of four pending arrest warrants connecting him to offences allegedly committed during the 2007 land agitation. The arrest took place shortly after Mamata extended her faction’s support to the Congress, prompted by TMC’s Sanchita Pradhan Dey, with-

drawing from the race. The BJP has fielded Hasirani Rath, mother of Chandranath Rath, the former aide of CM Suvendu Adhikari who was gunned down earlier this year. Ritabrata Banerjee-led TMC faction has fielded Mohammad Eteshamul Haque. In Rejinagar, Mamata-led TMC’s Rabiul Alam Chowdhury initially announced with-

drawal from the polls, citing difficulties due to contesting under the new symbol. He, however, reversed the decision within hours after speaking to the TMC supremo. Chowdhury is now contesting the bypolls under the EC-anointed Mamata All-India TMC and ‘football player’ symbol. The bypolls were necessitated after Adhikari vacated the Nandigram seat, and AJUP chief Humayun Kabir vacated Rejinagar. In Nagaon, Congress’s Sibamoni Bora is pitted against the BJP’s Devasish Sharma, a former IAS officer who resigned as the DC in September to enter politics, while AIUDD chief Badruddin Ajmal is also in the fray. The bypoll was necessitated after sitting Congress MP Pradyut Bordoloi joined the BJP. In Tamil Nadu, CM C. Joseph Vijay embarked on a roadshow in the Dharapuram (SC) in support of TVK candidate P. Sathyabama, and slammed the DMK for making remarks against women.

Bengal CM vows UCC in six months, strict laws against ‘love, land jihad’

RINKU BEHERA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday announced that his government would implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in the state within six months, following the examples of Uttarakhand and Gujarat, and bring in stringent laws against “love jihad”, “land jihad” and religious conversion. Addressing an event organised by the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) in Kolkata to mark the birth centenary of former VHP president Ashok Singhal, Adhikari said his government would function within the framework of the Constitution while taking steps to protect Indian culture, traditions and places of worship. “I am giving you my word. Very soon, after Uttarakhand and Gujarat, the UCC will be implemented in West Bengal. Give me six months,” he said. Adhikari added that after implementing the UCC, his government would work towards bringing strict laws against “love jihad”, “land

jihad” and religious conversions. The state government had constituted a nine-member committee, headed by retired Supreme Court Judge Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai, in July to examine and finalise the draft UCC Bill. The proposed legislation will provide a common framework for civil matters such as marriage, divorce, inheritance and adoption. The CM further said his government would protect cows and ensure that people could freely distribute and recite the Bhagavad Gita. He spoke of reviving the practice of studying the Vedas and protecting temples, monasteries and other heritage sites. Taking a swipe at the previous TMC government, Adhikari alleged that the earlier administration had created divisions between Bengalis and non-Bengalis. He said 20,000 people would gather in Kolkata on November 17 to recite the Hanuman Chalisa, while 10 lakh people would assemble on December 29 for a mass recitation of the Bhagavad Gita.

BJP questions Gandhis’ silence on bravery of flydubai captain

MANIKANT MISHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
The BJP has questioned the Gandhi family’s response to the bravery of flydubai pilot Captain Smit Machchhar, turning the episode into a political attack on the Congress leadership and its past positions on security-related issues. BJP MP Sudhanshu Trivedi questioned Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi over their silence on Machchhar, while referring to their alleged responses to Burhan Wani, Afzal Guru, Yakub Memon and the Batla House encounter. Trivedi asked why those who, according to him, had spoken out on these issues had not said anything about Machchhar, who had risked his life to save passengers. The BJP’s attack was aimed particularly at the Gandhi family, but Congress leaders have in fact publicly praised Machchhar’s actions. Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge on October 1 praised Machchhar and his crew for showing “remarkable presence of mind and exceptional courage” during the incident.

Cong slams Centre over retrospective green nod, welcomes SC intervention

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
The Congress on Sunday stepped up its attack on the Centre over retrospective environmental clearances, alleging that the practice had allowed project proponents to start work in violation of environmental laws and seek approvals later. Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the Supreme Court’s latest intervention had finally shut the door on such clearances in

future, but said that the exemption granted to projects that had already received retrospective approvals had diluted the impact of the verdict. Ramesh said the “ecologically damaging saga” of retrospective environmental clearances had continued through a series of judicial and executive interventions. “On May 16, 2025, a two-judge SC Bench categorically rejected such clearances. This was a bold verdict ... However, on November 18, 2025, a

three-judge Bench overturned the ruling,” he said. He cited another three-judge Bench unanimously striking down the provision for retrospective environmental clearances on July 29, 2026. Welcoming the July 29 judgment, Ramesh said it was a “most welcome development”. “But the verdict also allowed those cases where such approvals had already been granted to be taken forward, which diluted its impact,” he said. — TNS

Naxals’ fall opens up Bastar for malaria control

AKSHEEV THAKUR
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
The Chhattisgarh Government is scaling up health facilities, while the administration is working towards eliminating malaria in the tribal regions, especially Bijapur and Sukma, following the decline of Naxalism in the state. According to a 2025 study by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), Chhattisgarh recorded 3,91,387 malaria cases from 2015 to 2023. The annual parasite index (API)

was higher in Chhattisgarh’s southern districts (Bastar region), including Sukma, Bastar, Bijapur, Narayanpur and Kondagaon. Around 80 per cent of malaria reported in India is confined to 20 per cent of the population residing in tribal and hilly areas. Chhattisgarh is a centrally located state in India, with 32 per cent of its population residing in tribal and forested areas. The Centre aims to eradicate malaria by 2030. Speaking with The Tribune, Sukma collector, Amit Kumar said, “The gov-

ernment is scaling up efforts to eradicate malaria. Testing was conducted and quinine tablets were given to those affected. We gave artesunate injections to patients who did not recover despite taking quinine. We are also running ‘Malaria Mukta Bastar Abhiyan’; and have brought down the incidence of cases from 17 to 13 this time.” On incidence of sickle cell anaemia in the tribal belt of Chhattisgarh, Kumar said the disease was manageable, but malaria was a concern. Health officials requesting

anonymity said that earlier, robust testing of people could not happen owing to the presence of Naxalites. “Testing has scaled with the gradual decline in Naxalism. The Central Reserve Police Force’s (CRPF’s) field hospital is playing a major role as well. When the administration could not reach the hinterlands, security personnel reached and treated tribals,” he said, adding that with the state’s tough action against naxals, doctors were now opting to serve in tribal areas.

20th Asian Games

Aichi-Nagoya 2026

11

INDIA-PAKISTAN CRICKET AND HOCKEY MATCHES MOST VIEWED

NAGOYA: The men's cricket final and hockey semifinal between India and Pakistan were the most viewed matches in the Asian Games history, the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) said. India beat Pakistan 4-3 in the men's hockey semifinal at Kakamigahara. India went on to win the gold medal after beating Malaysia in the final. India also beat Pakistan by 19 runs in the men's cricket final.



KUMKUM, SUJEET INAUGURAL RECIPIENTS OF IOA AWARDS

NAGOYA: Archer Kumkum Mohod and wrestler Sujeteet Kalkal have been named the inaugural recipients of the Jaspal Rana Award and Raja Randhir Singh Award, respectively, by the Indian Olympic Association. Seventeen-year-old Mohod, making her Asian Games debut, won three medals, including two gold. Kalkal won gold in the men's 65kg freestyle category, defeating the reigning Olympics champion in the semifinals.



CHINA'S YU AND THAILAND'S BOONSON NAMED MVP

NAGOYA: China's 13-year-old swimmer Yu Zidi was named the female Most Valuable Player of the Games. Yu claimed three individual gold medals. She swam the second-fastest time in winning the 200 metres individual medley. Thailand's 20-year-old sprinter Puripol Boonson, who won the 100m and 200m gold medals with record-breaking runs, was named the men's MVP.

Country	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
China	169	89	83	341
Japan	83	95	91	269
Korea	39	43	68	150
India	21	27	37	85
Uzbekistan	21	25	24	70
Iran	19	18	15	52

Asian Games close after fortnight of turmoil and teenage triumph | Qatar to host next edition

NAGOYA, OCTOBER 4

The 20th Asian Games closed on Sunday after a rocky fortnight lit up by youthful brilliance in the sporting arenas but tempered by logistical dysfunction and subdued public interest. Olympic Council of Asia (OCA) president Sheikh Joaan bin Hamad Al Thani declared the Games closed at Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium, with the torch handed to organisers of the next event in Doha 2030.

Some 17,000 athletes and officials came for the Aichi-Nagoya showpiece, more than the Paris Olympics, competing in 469 gold-medal events spanning Tokyo to Osaka.

The massive scale clashed with organisers' planning for a "simple, streamlined and functional event" — and the results were often chaotic.

Athletes and teams complained of bungled accommodation and transport, prompting repeated apologies from the embarrassed organising committee. Despite the challenges, the Games were lifted by the performances of teenage titans, led by China's 13-year-old swimmer Yu Zidi.

Awarded the female Most Valuable Player of the Games, Yu is on track for a huge Los Angeles Olympics after claiming three individual gold medals in the Tokyo pool.

She swam the second-fastest time in winning the 200 metres individual medley, setting up a battle royale with Canada's world-record holder Summer McIntosh.

Her 19-year-old teammate Zhang Zhanshuo became the first swimmer to win seven gold medals at the Games, while Japan's 17-year-old wunderkind Shin Ohashi smashed the 200m breast-stroke world record.

Youthful brilliance lit up the athletics, with China's 18-year-old Yan Ziyi producing a world-class throw to win the women's javelin gold while 20-year-old Thai sprinter Puripol Boonson swept the 100m and 200m to become the men's MVP.

The athletes performed despite regular logistical failures and occasional diplomatic gaffes. Organisers opted to house athletes and officials in a mix of hotels, wooden container units and a cruise ship to cut costs rather than build a dedicated athletes' village.

They budgeted for 15,000 athletes and officials — about

Sayonara Aichi-Nagoya



CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: Dancers perform; Qatar's Jassim Al Kuwari with the OCA flag on horseback during the closing ceremony. REUTERS



Dazzling light and musical show

A dazzling light and musical show, sprinkled with a vibrant display of Japan's culture and hospitality, brought the curtains down on the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games as the host country pulled off a spectacular closing ceremony. To express the closing ceremony's concept of 'One Asia', a hexagonal stage was placed at the centre of the stadium, and it was the highlight of the show. It was adorned with lanterns, a quintessential symbol of Japanese summer, during the grand finale.

2,000 fewer than total registrations — and struggled to manage them. Waves of athletes spent up to 12 hours waiting to be registered on arrival.

When checking in, some found their rooms double-booked or being shared by the wrong teammates. Transport problems dogged the Games throughout, with athletes' shuttle buses failing to turn up or taking them to the wrong venues. Several competitions were delayed by the errors.

South Korea's delegation was particularly aggrieved, with its team chef de mis-

sion marking the Games' organisation with an 'F'.

Their men's football team was upset when the South Korean flag was unable to be hoisted for the national anthem at the victory ceremony after it beat Japan for the gold medal. The North Korean national anthem played for South Korea's men's hockey team earlier in the Games in another awkward mix-up.

Five years after the Tokyo Olympics was staged without fans due to Covid-19 restrictions, Japan's first major multi-sport event was blighted by poor crowds. Fewer than 1,000

spectators watched the hosts beat South Korea in the women's football semifinals at a 50,000-capacity stadium.

Much smaller venues were often nearly empty, though many were based in far-flung locations, making access a challenge. "I don't think it was a success," Nagoya resident Naoko Toda, who watched several competitions, said before the closing ceremony.

Despite the issues, the Games' governing OCA declared Aichi-Nagoya a success and praised organisers for their frugal arrangements. China topped the table with

169 gold among 341 medals, their best haul at an overseas Asian Games. But Japan also delivered for fans who tuned in, with 83 gold in a total of 269 medals, smashing their previous record at Hiroshima 1994. Padel, mixed martial arts, teqball and surfing made their Games debuts in a record 43-sport programme that dwarfed the Paris Olympics. Qatar is set to host the next Asiad in 2030, though the OCA may elect to push it back a year to serve as the continent's Olympic qualifiers before Brisbane 2032. — Reuters

NAGOYA, OCTOBER 4

India's sporting ambitions took a sobering reality check at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, where a campaign that promised another leap forward ended with a significant dip from the record-breaking haul in Hangzhou.

India retained the fourth place in the overall standings but finished with 85 medals — 21 gold, 27 silver and 37 bronze — 21 medals and seven gold fewer than the 106-medal haul, achieved in the last edition.

For a country chasing top-10 status by 2036 and a top-five ranking by 2047, the numbers are a reminder that sustaining progress will be far harder than producing a spectacular Games.

At the top, China remained untouchable, finishing with 341 medals, including 169 gold. Japan was second with 83 gold and 269 medals, while South Korea took third with 39 gold and 150 medals.

India's fourth-place finish still keeps it among Asia's leading sporting nations. That distinction matters. A fourth-place finish means India remains firmly within the continent's leading sporting pack, but the gap at the top is still enormous.

If it was not for a sensational gold rush in the last two days — when India won 11 gold medals — a top-five place was not possible. The biggest reason for the shortfall was the under-performance of two traditional medal pillars — shooting and athletics.

Both arrived with high



India's flag bearer Neeru Dhanda during the closing ceremony. PTI

expectations but left India with fewer medals than in Hangzhou, exposing vulnerabilities in consistency, pressure management and preparation. Shooting suffered a sharp fall. After producing a stunning seven gold, nine silver and six bronze medals last time, India's 30-member team returned from Japan with 15 medals — three gold, eight silver and four bronze.

The shooter who transformed the mood in the camp was Neeru Dhanda. The 27-year-old became the first Indian woman to win an individual Asian Games gold in trap shooting. She added a silver in the women's team event and another gold in the mixed team competition with Kynan Chenai. Yet Neeru's brilliance could not mask the broader concerns.

Athletics provided another major disappointment. India lost one of its biggest gold-

medal prospects even before the competition began when javelin ace Neeraj Chopra withdrew with injury.

The problems extended beyond the javelin.

Tajinderpal Singh Toor could not complete a hat-trick of Asian Games golds, while long jumper Murali Sreeshankar and high jumper Sarvesh Kushare also settled for silver.

Their performances showed India was competitive, but once again the gap between being in contention and finishing on top proved costly.

Injuries added to the setbacks as Jyothi Yarraji withdrew from the women's 100m hurdles before her opening heat after experiencing knee pain and discomfort during warm-up. Avinash Sable, returning from a serious knee injury, finished fourth in the men's 3000m steeplechase. — PTI



The Indian contingent during the athletes' parade at the closing ceremony. REUTERS

Djokovic rallies past Zverev in thriller to reach semifinals

CHINA OPEN

BEIJING, OCTOBER 4

Novak Djokovic produced a trademark comeback to defeat top seed Alexander Zverev 4-6 6-4 6-4 and reach the China Open semifinals on Sunday, extending his unbeaten record in the tournament. Playing the ATP 500 event in Beijing for the first time since 2015, the six-time champion was pushed to the limit by reigning French Open and US Open champion Zverev, who delivered 19 aces in the match.

Meeting for the first time in nearly 16 months, Djokovic struggled to contain the German's power in the early stages as the 29-year-old Zverev claimed the opening set, but the Serb gradually



Novak Djokovic celebrates his win; Aryna Sabalenka walks off after her defeat. REUTERS

worked his way into the match and refused to let his opponent pull away.

The contest was briefly interrupted by a moment of controversy when Zverev

argued that LED advertising signage had gone dark during a rally and requested a video review after losing the point.

Replays showed a section



of the signage had switched off, though not as Zverev was missing the forehand. The chair umpire ordered the point to be replayed, prompting a frustrated

exchange from Djokovic.

The turning point came late in the second set when Djokovic broke at 5-4 to level the match, shifting the momentum in his favour

after a tightly contested battle. With little separating the pair in the third, the Serbian struck again at 5-4 on the Zverev serve, securing the decisive break to seal victory in two hours and 35 minutes.

Sabalenka bundled out

Aryna Sabalenka crashed out in the third round following a 6-4 6-3 by Czech Nikola Pietrangola, the latest setback in a frustrating season for the world No. 2.

Sabalenka was broken in the opening game and squandered five opportunities to break back in the sixth game of the first set, before going on to lose the match in an hour and 35 minutes. "I focused on myself, to be calm," Bartunkova, 20, said. — Reuters

Yamal and Kane star in Nations League wins

LONDON, OCTOBER 4

Ballon d'Or rivals Lamine Yamal and Harry Kane starred as Spain and England won their matches in the Nations League.

Both are in contention to win the prestigious award on October 26.

Kane scored twice as England crushed Croatia 7-0 away and Yamal scored another brilliant curling shot from outside the penalty area as Spain won at home to Czechia 3-1 for a 40th game unbeaten.

The 2024 Ballon d'Or winner Rodri and substitute Mikel Merino also scored as Spain recorded a third straight win to stay three points ahead of Eng-

land in their Nations League A group.

With his brace of goals, Kane extended his national record to 89 international goals — 36 more than Wayne Rooney in second place on England's list of scorers. Right winger Bukayo Saka also netted twice, while left winger Anthony Gordon set up Jude Bellingham's goal and grabbed one himself. Substitute Morgan Rogers completed the rout in Rijeka.

"We were so fluid right from the start. It just never stopped," England coach Thomas Tuchel said. "We just kept the pace up and played through the gaps. We were very, very clinical." — AP

GST set for another big reform; officers may lose arrest powers

After last year’s rate reset, focus shifts to compliance, prosecution norms

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4
The GST Council is expected to take up this week a sweeping overhaul of enforcement provisions that would strip tax officials of arrest powers and make prior court approval mandatory for any arrest, according to people familiar with the proposal. If approved, the move could emerge as a key pillar of the government’s next-generation GST reforms aimed at strengthening due process and improving ease of doing business.

The council is also likely to consider, at its October 7 meeting, a package of prosecution-related reforms, including raising the threshold for launching criminal proceedings for offences to Rs 5 crore.

The proposals also seek to narrow the scope of prosecution provisions so they do not apply to routine disputes over classification, valuation or input tax credit, where businesses and tax authorities may hold differing interpretations of the same transaction, they said.

The proposed enforcement



SIMPLER RULES FOR ONLINE BUSINESSES

GST Council may consider wide-ranging reforms, including easier registration, protection for genuine buyers’ tax credit, fewer low-value disputes & simplified norms for e-commerce sellers



GOLD IMPORT EXEMPTION MAY END

The council is likely to consider withdrawing IGST exemption on gold, silver and platinum imports by banks and agencies, placing them on a par with bullion exchanges and other importers

TAX CREDIT BOOST FOR EMPLOYEE INSURANCE

Employers may soon be allowed to claim input tax credit on GST paid for employee health/life insurance premiums. It could lower coverage costs, encourage wider insurance adoption

changes are part of the government’s next-generation GST reform agenda, following the major rate rationalisation implemented in September 2025. That overhaul simplified the GST structure around a 5 per cent merit rate and an 18 per cent standard rate, with a 40 per cent rate for select luxury and demer-

it goods. The next phase is expected to focus on simplifying administration, reducing compliance costs and making enforcement more proportionate.

A wider package under consideration includes easier registration, faster refunds, simpler input-tax-credit procedures and changes to show-cause notices

and penalties, the people said.

At the centre of the enforcement proposal is Section 69 of the Central GST Act, which allows the commissioner, where statutory conditions are met, and there are reasons to believe specified offences have been committed, to authorise an officer to arrest a person. The proposed changes would remove that power from tax officials. Any arrest would instead require judicial authorisation, they noted.

They said the proposed changes would not remove the government’s ability to recover taxes or impose financial penalties. Compounding would allow an offence to be settled, subject to payment of the prescribed tax, interest and penalty. Taxpayers found to have short-paid tax or wrongly claimed input tax credit would continue to face recovery proceedings and other statutory consequences.

Serious cases involving deliberate evasion or fraud could continue to be prosecuted through the courts, they said. — PTI

Keralam reopens probe into CEC-linked project

RINKU BEHERA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala has ordered a Vigilance probe into alleged corruption in a Kerala State Transport Project (KSTP) road work and the 2006 death of a Malaysian contractor associated with the project when incumbent Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was serving as the state’s PWD Secretary.

The move comes amid mounting Opposition protests and demands for Kumar’s resignation over the Election Commission’s special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across the country. Chennithala ordered the probe after KPCC leader Malayinkeezhu Vengopal submitted a complaint on Saturday, seeking an investigation into Kumar’s alleged role in the matter.

Sources said the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau had been asked to conduct a preliminary inquiry before any further action was considered.

The case relates to the death by suicide of Malaysian civil engineer Lee See Been, who was associated with the PATI-BEL consortium involved in

the upgrade of the MC road under the KSTP. Kumar was serving in the Public Works Department at the time.

Talking to the media, Chennithala said he had forwarded a petition alleging malpractices and corruption involving incumbent Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar during his tenure as the state’s PWD Secretary to the Vigilance Director for a detailed inquiry.

Chennithala said the petition, submitted by Congress activist Malayinkeezhu Vengopal, raised “serious issues” concerning Kumar’s tenure in the PWD.

The minister also referred to the death of Malaysian project engineer Lee, saying the engineer had allegedly died by suicide and that his suicide note mentioned Kumar, who was serving as the PWD Secretary at the time.

“The government cannot sit idle. I cannot become a mute spectator,” Chennithala said.

A Vigilance inquiry had been ordered following Been’s death in 2006. However, the investigation did not progress further and Kumar subsequently moved to the Defence Ministry on deputation.



Participants during the Sekhon Indian Air Force Marathon in Chandigarh on Sunday. ANI

5K run in memory of IAF hero Sekhon

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

CHANDIGARH, OCTOBER 4

The Sekhon Indian Air Force Marathon-2026, organised in memory of Flying Officer Nirmal Jit Singh Sekhon, the IAF’s sole Param Vir Chakra (PVC) recipient, was held here on Sunday, with about 5,000 people participating.

Fitness enthusiasts, professional athletes, serving personnel, veterans, students and youth from Chandigarh, Panchkula, Mohali and adjoining areas participated with great enthusiasm.

The event, held across several categories, distances and age groups, honoured Flying Officer Sekhon’s supreme sacrifice, courage and unwavering commitment to the nation while promoting fitness, discipline and national spirit.

During the 1971 India-Pakistan War, Sekhon, who hailed from Ludhiana and was then 28, was deployed at Srinagar air base with No. 18 Squadron, the ‘Flying Bullets’.

On December 14, Sekhon and another officer scrambled to counter an attack by Pakistani aircraft. He shot down three enemy Sabre jets in aerial combat before his own aircraft was hit and he went down. He was posthumously awarded the nation’s highest gallantry award, the Param Vir Chakra.

No. 18 Squadron was formed on April 15, 1965, with Gnat fighter aircraft. It first saw action in 1971, when it was tasked with defending the Kashmir valley and was awarded Battle Honours for its operational performance.

The squadron was decommissioned, or “number-plat-

ed” in Air Force terminology, in 2015 after its MiG-27 aircraft were retired.

It was resurrected in April 2020 at Suler Air Force Station in Tamil Nadu with the indigenous Tejas Mk-1 fighter and later relocated to Naliya airbase in Gujarat.

Air Marshal George Thomas, Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Air Command, was the chief guest. Later, he visited Headquarters Western Command at Chandimandir and interacted with his Army counterpart, Lt Gen Pushpendra Singh.

The Air Marshal was briefed on the operational environment and preparedness along the western front. The interaction reinforced inter-services synergy, integrated planning and a joint war-fighting approach to addressing contemporary operational challenges.

TMC rebel Mal among 15 MPs cleared for UNGA delegation

ADITI TANDON
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Trinamool Congress rebel Asit Kumar Mal is in the first lot of 15 MPs cleared by the government to attend the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly in New York from October 5 to 9. The first 15-member Indian parliamentary delegation consists of nine members of the ruling BJP and its allies and supporting parties in Parliament and six from the Opposition camp. The first tranche has 10 Lok Sabha and five Rajya Sabha MPs.

There are six parliamentarians from the BJP and one each from the JDU and YSR-CP, which backs the ruling NDA in Parliament.

Mal, a two-term MP from West Bengal’s Bolpur, is also on the panel and represents the rebel Trinamool Congress camp, which calls itself the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI). The validity of the NCPI claim, however, is under the consideration of Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, who is also in receipt of a counter petition from the Abhishek Banerjee-led

Four MPs allowed to travel with families

TMC camp in the Lok Sabha, which contests NCPI’s claim of independence from the TMC in the Lower House. The Speaker is yet to rule on the matter, and Parliament records still describe Mal as a Trinamool Congress member.

The Tribune has further exclusively learnt that four Lok Sabha MPs on the delegation have been cleared to travel with their families.

These include BJP’s Tripura West MP and national general secretary Biplab Kumar Deb, who will travel with his wife, Triveni Deb; Congress MP Rahul Kaswan from Rajasthan’s Churu constituency, who has been permitted to travel with his wife, Neelu Kaswan; Samajwadi Party MP Priya Saroj from Machhlishahr (SC), who will be accompanied by her father, Tufani Saroj; and Araku (ST) MP Gumma Thanuja Rani, who will travel with her spouse, Vinay Chetti, and their three-year-old daughter, Yashnaa Chetti.

The following Opposition

MPs are part of the first delegation: Rahul Kaswan and Anil Kumar Yadav Mandadi of the Congress; Priya Saroj of the Samajwadi Party; Rajabhau Parag Prakash Waje, a first-term Lok Sabha MP of the Shiv Sena (UBT) from Nashik, Maharashtra; LK Sudhish, a first-term MP of the DMKD, which was part of the DMK-led alliance for the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly polls; and RJD Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Yadav from Bihar.

The BJP and NDA Lok Sabha members in the delegation are BJP’s CP Joshi, a third-term MP from Chittorgarh, Rajasthan; JDU’s Lovely Anand, a second-term MP from Sheohar, Bihar; BJP’s Biplab Deb, a first-term MP from Tripura West; BJP’s Vishveshwar Hegde, a first-term MP from Uttara Kannada in Karnataka; BJP’s Mahima Kumari Mewar, a first-time MP from Rajsamand, Rajasthan.

From the Rajya Sabha, two first-term BJP MPs have been named in the high-profile delegation — Sikander Kumar from Himachal Pradesh and Bansilal Gurjar from Madhya Pradesh.

Lashkar’s Musa used honey to heal bullet wounds in hideout

SRINAGAR/NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

A top Pakistani terrorist, believed to be a former commando of the Pakistan army’s elite Special Services Group (SSG), had turned to age-old Ayurvedic treatment of using pure honey to treat his bullet wounds for early healing while hiding deep in the forests of J&K, officials said on Sunday.

Mohd Asif, alias Hashim Musa, the chief operational commander of the banned Lashkar-e-Tiba (LeT) in the region and one of the masterminds of the 2025 Pahalgam terror attack, was killed in a high-altitude operation by the Army in Yousmarg in Budgam district of central Kashmir earlier this week.

According to the officials, Musa sustained bullet injuries during an earlier encounter in the Dorimal-Gambhir Moghla area during ‘Operation Sheruwalli’ in Rajouri area of the Jammu region. The operation continued for more than 45 days to hunt for the two trapped terrorists, who, it later

emerged, were Musa and his associate Yasir.

While holed up inside the jungles of Poonch and Rajouri, the terrorist applied honey to his wounds, tapping into its Ayurvedic healing properties to accelerate tissue recovery and prevent infection in the wild because he could not access medical treatment due to the security cordon around the area, the officials said.

After Yasir’s death in the higher reaches of Yousmarg in the first week of September, a phone was recovered from him in which pictures were found of the honey-treated injuries of Musa. They were transmitted across the border to their handlers in Pakistan to apprise them of the top terrorist’s health condition, the officials said. The handlers were issuing instructions to ensure that the honey was pure as this would help in the quick healing of Musa, who was allegedly involved in a dozen terror attacks. — PTI

REGIONAL JOURNAL

UNTOLD STORIES FROM THE STATES

Emotional farewell for Warring

It was a brief but emotional farewell for Amrinder Singh Raja Warring when he formally handed over his resignation as the Punjab Congress chief to Rahul Gandhi on Friday. However, it was Rahul’s reassuring words that appeared to matter most. “I will take care of you,” Rahul told Warring during their meeting, sources said. Warring later recalled the warmth of the meeting, saying Rahul “gave me a lot of love”.

When Badal Sr forgot son’s name

Former Punjab CM Parkash Singh Badal once forgot his son Sukhbir’s name during a visit to The Lawrence School, Sanawar. Recalling the incident at an interaction with youngsters in Patiala, Sukhbir said Badal referred to Sukhbir by his nickname, ‘Lali’. The principal said there was no student by that name. Badal then identified Sukhbir as a student from Punjab, following which the principal arranged the meeting.

Khuddian finds a friend in Chouhan

Amid Punjab and Centre’s never-ending political cold war, Agriculture Minister Gurmeet Singh Khuddian appears to have struck a productive rapport with Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan. At the National Agriculture Conference, Khuddian sought a subsidy for wheat seeds, and nearly Rs 50 crore was approved swiftly. Another Rs 43.12 crore under the Krishi Unnati scheme soon followed. While Punjab continues to pursue pending RDF and flood-relief dues from the Centre, Khuddian’s success has caught political attention.

A Ramayana take on govt postings

How does one explain the irrational deployment of staff in the government sector? Perhaps that is why a senior Himachal bureaucrat reached back to the Ramayana for an analogy. Recalling the televised epic, he said when arrows fired by Rama and Ravana collided, the weaker one disappeared. Similarly, in appointments, an arrow of administrative logic often meets an arrow of political influence, and the stronger one determines the posting. Most of the time, he said, administrative logic prevails.

SP, Sholay and UP polls

Legendary dialogues of the blockbuster film ‘Sholay’ have made a sudden entry to the social media feeds, thanks to the Samajwadi Party’s digital teams. The videos curated using AI have raised the hackles of the BJP as they show SP chief Akhilesh Yadav as the hero and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath as the villain. Opposition MPs are busy amplifying the videos on Meta platforms these days.

When Sonia patted Mamata

The Opposition INDIA bloc meeting in the capital this week stood out for a video in which Congress veteran Sonia Gandhi was seen affectionately patting the back of embattled Trinamool Congress leader Mamata Banerjee. The gesture came after Mamata’s challenge to the BJP: “Hum ladenge, hum jeetenge, loktantra wapis aayega (we will fight and win and democracy will be restored).”

Charity raises questions

The family of gangster Jaggu Bhagwanpuria is once again organising mass marriages for destitute girls, leaving the police with more questions than answers. Senior officers say they are yet to ascertain the source of funds for the events and gift items. Rumours are rife that extortion money may be involved, though the police have chosen to remain tight-lipped.

Games, but who pays?

With funds for Centre- and block-level school games yet to be released, government primary schools are allegedly being asked to contribute Rs 10,000 per block for district-level competitions. Democratic Teachers’ Front leader Davinder Singh Sidhu said schools faced mounting financial pressure as even last year’s sanctioned funds remain unpaid. He said organising a block-level event cost about Rs 1 lakh, while the approved budget was only Rs 5,000. Schools had contributed Rs 6,000 per block for the games last year, he added.

Ground reality bites

A week before the Nasha Mukti Yatra finale, the BJP projected Amit Shah’s September 30 Jalandhar rally as a mega show, planning a 60-acre venue and 2,000 buses from across Punjab. But local leaders said far fewer buses reached the ground, resulting in a thinner turnout than anticipated.

Contributed by Shekhar Singh, Archit Watts, Ruchika M Khanna, Subhash Rajta, Aditi Tandon, Ravi Dhaliwal, Sukhpreet Singh and Deepkamal Kaur

HIT BY SUV, ELDERLY COUPLE INJURED; WOMAN DRIVER HELD

A 72-year-old woman and her 78-year-old husband were injured after an SUV hit them in Kirti Nagar on Friday. **P2»**



F'BAD POLICE ARREST 45 CYBER CRIMINALS IN WEEK

The Faridabad police arrested 45 cyber fraudsters in a week and seized ₹13,48,600 from them. **P3»**



BOLLYWOOD'S GOOD GUYS GONE BAD

Here's a look at the stars who showed that being the bad guy can be just as memorable as being the hero. **P4»**



FORECAST
CLEAR SKY
TEMPERATURE
DELHI
MAX: 36°C MIN: 24°C
GURUGRAM
MAX: 36°C MIN: 22°C
FARIDABAD
MAX: 36°C MIN: 23°C
NOIDA
MAX: 36°C MIN: 25°C
SUNSET
MONDAY 6:03 PM
SUNRISE
TUESDAY 6:16 AM

AIR QUALITY INDEX	
DELHI	187
GURUGRAM	166
FARIDABAD	224
GREATER NOIDA	171
GHAZIABAD	248
NOIDA	281
401-500	SEVERE
301-400	VERY POOR
201-300	POOR
101-200	MODERATE
51-100	SATISFACTORY
0-50	GOOD

INBRIEF

FIRE BREAKS OUT AT GARMENT FACTORY

New Delhi: A fire broke out at a garment factory in Pratap Gali, Gandhi Nagar, on Sunday morning, officials said. The fire was reported around 10:06 am from the second floor of the garment factory in the Geeta Colony area. Three water tenders, two water-bowser units, a quick response vehicle and a motorcycle fire response vehicle were pressed into service to douse the flames. The blaze was brought under control around 11:10 am, according to the Fire Department. No injuries or casualties were reported. Further investigation is underway. **TNS**

HELPLINE

Emergency response: 112

Women Helpline: 1091

Special cell (Northeast): 1093

Missing person: 1094

Vigilance: 1064

Senior citizens: 1291

WHAT'S ON

DELHI

Film: "Ivan The Terrible — Part I (1945; 95 min; Black-and-white; Russian with English subtitles); India International Centre: 6:30 pm

Film: "EcoReels 2026. The Becoming of a Wildscape (Docu/2026/English, Tamil, Kannada with English subtitles/18 mins); India Habitat Centre: 7 pm

Scattered, leaderless protests put over 5K Delhi cops to test

Small groups, multiple timings turn central Delhi into agitation zone

MANIKANT MISHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

It was not the size of the crowd that tested the Delhi Police over the past three days, but where the protesters kept appearing.

Unlike the much larger mobilisation associated with the Cockroach Janta Party's earlier agitation, the latest protests demanding Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar's resignation remained relatively limited and fragmented. Yet groups turning up at different points and at different times across the New Delhi district repeatedly disrupted traffic and civic movement, forcing the police to secure several stretches rather than manage one



Policemen detain a student during a protest in New Delhi on Sunday. **TRIBUNE PHOTO: MANAS RANJAN BHUI**

consolidated gathering.

The AAP, Congress-linked groups, student organisations and Left outfits held or announced separate protests, while different groups attempted to move towards

The police had deployed around 5,000 personnel, including RAF and paramilitary forces, and said permission had not been granted for the proposed marches.

The political fragmentation was also visible after the AAP and Congress exchanged barbs on social media over the CJP agitation. Rather than producing one opposition-led mobilisation, the competing calls left protesters scattered around India Gate, Ashoka Road, Janpath, Tolstoy Road and the approaches to Jantar Mantar.

NO CONSOLIDATED MARCH REACHES PROTEST SITE

That fragmentation created a peculiar law-and-order situation: protesters repeatedly

CONTINUED ON PAGE 3

Youth Cong, NSUI workers take to streets, seek CEC's ouster, arrest

ANSHITA MEHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

The Indian Youth Congress (IYC) and the National Students' Union of India (NSUI) held separate protests in Delhi on Sunday, demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over concerns regarding the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the functioning of the Election Commission.

The IYC organised a protest march from Raisina Road towards Jantar Mantar, with hundreds of youth workers carrying candles, placards and raising slogans against the government. The march was held amid heavy police deployment and barricading along the route.

IYC national president Uday Bhanu Chib accused the Delhi Police of preventing protesters from reaching Jantar Mantar and alleged that the Centre was shielding Kumar.



Indian Youth Congress members take out a candlelight march in New Delhi on Sunday. **TRIBUNE PHOTO: MANAS RANJAN BHUI**

CENTRE SHIELDING KUMAR, SAYS CHIB

Indian Youth Congress national president Uday Bhanu Chib accused the Delhi Police of preventing protesters from reaching Jantar Mantar and alleged that the Centre was shielding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Chib said the protesters would continue their march towards Jantar Mantar and criticised the government over what he described as a lack of accountability in the electoral process.

IYC national secretary Roshani Jaiswal also accused the government of attempting to suppress the issue and said the organisation would continue its protests.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 3

INDIA bloc parties to step up stir against CEC

ANSHITA MEHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Delhi units of the INDIA bloc parties on Sunday decided to intensify their agitation against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, announcing district-level protests on October 7 and 8 and a mass demonstration at the office of the Chief Electoral Officer on November 7.

Representatives of the Congress, RJD, CPI(M), CPI, CPI(ML), RSP, All-India Forward Bloc and Trinamool Congress met at HKS Surjeet Bhawan to chalk out a coordinated action plan following the bloc's national-level meeting on September 30.

The parties reiterated their demand for the resig-

To hold district-level protests on Oct 7, 8

nation of Kumar and roll-back of the SIR, while calling for the restoration of names of genuine voters allegedly excluded from the electoral rolls during the revision process in Delhi.

According to the parties, more than 47 lakh names have been deleted from the draft electoral roll in Delhi under the SIR, while another 31.6 lakh voters have been served notices by the Election Commission seeking proof of their eligibility.

The parties also alleged that the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer had failed to follow due process while carrying out the revision, particularly

CONTINUED ON PAGE 3

Plaint against Delhi ACP over 'molestation' transferred to Crime Branch for fair probe

ANSHITA MEHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

A complaint alleging sexual harassment by Delhi Police ACP Vivek Bhagat during a protest in the New Delhi area on Saturday has been transferred to the Crime Branch for a "fair and impartial inquiry", the police said on Sunday.

The development came after three women, who identified themselves as journalists, approached the police with complaints alleging manhandling and sexual harassment by police personnel during their detention while officers were managing the law and order situation at the October 3 protest.

One of the complainants, a woman content creator who identified herself as Seema



Neha Bora (2nd left), national president of AISA, along with members of other organisations, during a protest in New Delhi. **MANAS RANJAN BHUI**

(name changed), alleged that Bhagat touched her inappropriately and pushed her while she was recording the detention of protester Neha Bora. The allegation could not be independently verified.

DCP Neha Yadav said Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) had been imposed in the area when AISA and other organisations staged a protest against the Special Intensive

PRESS CLUB, OTHERS FLAY WOMAN SCRIBE'S 'HARASSMENT'

The Press Club of India and the Indian Women's Press Corps on Sunday condemned the alleged sexual harassment of a woman journalist by a senior Delhi Police officer during protests at Jantar Mantar and demanded immediate action on her complaint. In separate statements, the journalist bodies also criticised the alleged aggressive treatment of mediapersons by the police during protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Friday and Saturday.

Revision (SIR) on October 3.

"Protesters were warned to vacate the site, citing Section 163 of the BNSS. Upon their refusal to comply, they were detained," Yadav said.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 3

Thieves strike at BJP MP's Lutyens' Delhi bungalow

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

A break-in at the official residence of Rajiya Sabha MP Dr Radha Mohan Das Agrawal has raised questions over security in the high-security VIP area of central Delhi, after thieves entered his government bungalow on Ferozeshah Road and stole a tablet and other essential items, bathroom taps and even a drain cover from the premises.

The incident took place at bungalow number 18 while the MP and his family were away from Delhi.

Flee with tablet, bathroom taps, drain cover

EV race hits charging test as 2027 deadline nears

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Delhi has cleared a major infrastructure hurdle for its electric-vehicle transition, but the real test now is how quickly chargers reach the ground before mandatory EV-registration deadlines begin.

The Ministry of Heavy Industries has approved 382 of the 456 sites identified by Delhi's Revenue Department and the Delhi Transport Corporation. The sites have been reassessed for two-, three- and four-wheelers, taking into account electricity availability and grid capacity.

The urgency is driven by deadlines already built into Delhi's new EV policy. From January 1, 2027, only electric three-wheelers and N1 light commercial vehicles will be eligible for new registration, while the electric-only rule for new two-wheelers begins on April 1, 2028.

Yet the approval of sites is not the same as chargers being operational. The government is preparing tenders for the first 160-

382 SITES CLEARED

The Ministry of Heavy Industries has approved 382 of the 456 sites identified by Delhi's Revenue Department and the Delhi Transport Corporation. The sites have been reassessed for two-, three- and four-wheelers, taking into account electricity availability and grid capacity.



180 high-readiness locations, leaving the rollout of the remaining approved sites to subsequent stages.

That makes implementation the real hook. Delhi is moving towards restricting new petrol and CNG vehicle registrations while its supporting charging network is still being rolled out. For commuters, fleet operators and delivery businesses, the pace of that rollout could determine whether the transition is convenient or creates a new infrastructure bottleneck.

Ridge gets legal shield as reserved forest cover surges 54-fold

MANIKANT MISHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Delhi is moving to put a substantially larger part of its Ridge under the stricter legal protection of reserved forests, taking the notified area from just 96.16 hectares under earlier governments to 5,267.009 hectares under the present government, an increase of nearly 54 times.

Notified area up from 96.16 hectares to 5,267.009 hectares

The next addition is 112,328 hectares of the Northern Ridge, which the Delhi Government is now moving to notify as reserved forest. Once notified, the total reserved forest area in the city will rise to 5,363.169 hectares, or about 13,252 acres.

The significance of the move goes beyond the size of the number. Reserved-forest status gives the administration a stronger legal framework to deal with activities such as encroachment, unauthorised construction and tree felling in protected areas.

Real test begins after notification

The government had also approved the inclusion of around 400 hectares of additional Southern Ridge land as reserved forest last month, widening the legal protection around one of Delhi's most critical natural assets.

The Ridge is not merely open green land. It forms an important ecological buffer for the Capital, supporting biodiversity and groundwater recharge while helping maintain the city's environmental balance.

But the sharp expansion of the notified area also raises a more immediate administrative question of how much of

CONTINUED ON PAGE 3

11 layers of barricades turn Jantar Mantar into fortress

GROUND REPORT

MANIKANT MISHRA
TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Jantar Mantar, Delhi's designated protest venue, has effectively been turned into a heavily secured enclosure, with 11 layers of barricading surrounding the protest ground—six on the rear side and five on the front.

A visit by *The Tribune* found that the main entrance as well as the rear approaches had been blocked by successive barricades, backed by Delhi Police, Central Indus-

trial Security Force (CISF) and Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel. Around 300 personnel were estimated to be deployed within the barricaded zone during the visit. The figure is a ground estimate and not an official police deployment figure.

6 LAYERS SEAL THE REAR

The rear side of the protest ground has six successive layers of barricading. One approach comes from the Jantar Mantar Road, along the Kerala House side, while another connects towards Sansad Marg, near the Parliament Street police station. Both approaches have been blocked.

Around 300 personnel deployed within the barricaded zone



Multi-layer barricades put up in Jantar Mantar. PHOTO BY WRITER

The barricading continues along the stretch where roadside eateries are located behind the protest ground. Beyond these outlets, the road towards the Parliament Street side is also sealed, preventing access from the rear.

The Jantar Mantar lane connects the Jantar Mantar

Road with Sansad Marg, making the area an important link between the two sides of the protest venue.

5 LAYERS GUARD THE FRONT

The principal entrance from the Janpath Metro station's Gate No. 2 side has also been blocked. From the Ashoka Road side, the first security layer blocks the approach towards the Royal Plaza area. Another layer near the 21, Ashoka Road, bungalow complex prevents movement towards Kerala House and Sardar Patel Library.

A further set of barricades begins near Kerala House, followed by additional barricading closer to the rear of the protest

ground and finally another directly blocking protest site.

On the other side, approaches from the Janpath and Imperial Hotel side have also been restricted. Barricading has been placed near the other gate of the Janpath Metro station near Mordern Service Station's petrol pump side.

BARRICADES SIX TO EIGHT FEET HIGH

The security arrangement is not a single line of police barriers. Several barricades have been joined together, creating multiple successive layers. Many are around six to eight feet high and carry Delhi Police markings.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Good governance sustains investor confidence: Vice-Prez

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4 Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday said good governance was the “invisible infrastructure” sustaining investor confidence and called upon company secretaries to uphold transparency, accountability and ethical standards amid rapid technological changes.

Addressing the 58th Foundation Day celebrations of the Institute of Company Secretaries of India (ICSI) at Bharat Mandapam, Radhakrishnan described company secretaries as “guardians of governance” and said they had an important role in strengthening corporate transparency and India’s position in the global economy.

“Technology may transform the manner in which information is generated and decisions are supported, but integrity, accountability, transparency and responsibility remain human,” he said.

Radhakrishnan said trust, transparency and corporate governance were essential

58th foundation day celebrations of the Institute of Company Secretaries of India



Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan

TRUST, TRANSPARENCY MUST FOR PROGRESS

- Radhakrishnan said trust, transparency and corporate governance were essential for sustained economic progress and that company secretaries played a key role in enabling enterprises, start-ups, family businesses and listed companies to grow responsibly.
- “Technology may transform the manner in which information is generated and decisions are supported, but integrity, accountability, transparency and responsibility remain human,” he said.
- He also highlighted the role of ICSI, the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) and the Institute of Cost Accountants of India (ICMAI) as institutional pillars in India’s journey towards Viksit Bharat @2047.

for sustained economic progress and that company secretaries played a key role in enabling enterprises, start-ups, family businesses and listed companies to grow responsibly.

He also highlighted the role of ICSI, the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) and the Institute of Cost Accountants of India (ICMAI) as institutional pillars in India’s journey towards Viksit Bharat @2047.

The Vice-President called for greater opportunities for young people to enter the

profession and appreciated ICSI’s fee-waiver initiatives and student outreach programmes. He launched the MSME Compliance Calendar 2027 and appreciated initiatives for MSMEs and start-ups.

Radhakrishnan said India should aspire to become the world’s largest economy not to dictate terms to others “so that no one can dictate unwanted terms to us”.

Stresses Jain values of forgiveness, non-violence

Addressing the Mahaparva Kshamapana Ceremony

2026 at Vigyan Bhawan, Radhakrishnan highlighted the Jain principles of forgiveness and non-violence.

He said forgiveness meant choosing “reform over revenge, dialogue over hatred and reconciliation over hostility” and described ahimsa as the absence of violence in thought, words and deeds.

Referring to Viksit Bharat @2047, he said development should also encompass trust among citizens, values in families, character among youth and compassion in society.

City hospital's walkathon flagged off

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

Delhi BJP president and Union Minister Harsh Malhotra on Sunday flagged off the second edition of Sant Parmanand Hospital’s ‘Walkathon 2.0’ at Kashmere Gate, with around 3,000 to 3,500 people participating, according to the organisers.

Speaking at the event, Malhotra described the initiative as an effort towards preventive healthcare, saying medical institutions generally focus on curative treatment, while activities such as walking, yoga and sports can encourage people to stay fit and healthy.

He said the walkathon encouraged people to incorporate physical activity into their daily lives and linked the initiative with Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s emphasis on fitness and yoga.

Malhotra congratulated the management of Sant Parmanand Hospital for organising the event and said such initiatives could help promote awareness about preventive healthcare among the public.

Cleanliness drive: DDA collects 2.5 tonnes of waste from sports complexes

Special month-long campaign was launched on Sept 17

ANSHITA MEHRA

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has launched a month-long ‘Swachhata Hi Seva’ campaign across its parks, green spaces, sports complexes and recreational facilities, with around 2.5 tonnes of waste collected from sports complexes so far.

The campaign, which began on September 17, is being conducted under the guidance of Delhi Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and focuses on cleanliness, environmental improvement, public awareness and Jan Bhagidari.

As part of the drive, the DDA has undertaken cleanliness and sanitation work at several sports facilities, including the Saket Sports Complex, Netaji Subhash Sports Complex, Hari Nagar Sports Complex, Paschim Vihar Sports Complex, Dwarka Sports Complexes in Sectors 11 and 17, Major Dhyan Chand Sports Complex, Yamuna Sports Complex and Qutab Golf Course, among others.

The work has covered



sports and recreational facilities, parking areas, green spaces and other public-use areas. The DDA has also installed green and blue twin dustbins to facilitate segregation of wet and dry waste, along with anti-littering signage. Single-use plastic bottles have been prohibited at the facilities, while water dispensers and steel dustbins have been installed.

The campaign features three special initiatives — ‘Children to the Green - Learn, Care & Participate’, ‘Bin Before Overflow’ and ‘Capital’s Promise’. The first involves children and students in cleanliness and environmental awareness activities, while ‘Bin Before Overflow’ focuses on regular

monitoring and timely emptying of dustbins. ‘Capital’s Promise’ focuses on cleanliness and upkeep of public toilet facilities in and around recreational areas.

The DDA is also undertaking plantation of native tree species and awareness activities on waste disposal, prevention of littering, protection of trees and responsible use of public facilities.

A total of 75 RWAs, students, park users and people associated with public spaces are participating in the campaign. The DDA said the initiative aims to encourage a sense of ownership among residents so that cleanliness and responsible use of public spaces continue beyond the campaign period.

Hit by SUV, elderly couple injured

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

A 72-year-old woman and her 78-year-old husband were injured after a Hyundai Creta hit them in west Delhi’s Kirti Nagar on Friday morning. The 49-year-old woman driving the SUV was arrested, the police said.

The incident took place around 8.45 am on the Arya Samaj Mandir road. A CCTV footage shows the couple walking along the left side of the road when the SUV hit them, throwing them onto the road.

The woman, Kusum Tagra, who was carrying a walking stick and a crossbody bag, was thrown towards the roadside and landed near an electric pole. Her husband, Dayanand Tagra, was pushed onto the bonnet of the SUV before being thrown onto the road.

Passersby and people working nearby rushed to help the couple. The two were taken to Kalra Hospital, where they remain under treatment.

Additional DCP (West) Abhishek Gupta said the woman had suffered a spinal injury, while the man had a blood clot in his head.

“Further investigation is on. Taking cognisance of the matter, an FIR was immediately registered under the relevant sec-

Woman driver arrested, incident captured on CCTV camera

- The incident took place around 8.45 am on the Arya Samaj Mandir road. A CCTV footage shows the couple walking along the left side of the road when the SUV hit them, throwing them onto the road.
- The woman, Kusum Tagra, who was carrying a walking stick and a crossbody bag, was thrown towards the roadside and landed near an electric pole. Her husband, Dayanand Tagra, was pushed onto the bonnet of the SUV before being thrown onto the road.
- Passersby and people working nearby rushed to help the couple. The two were taken to Kalra Hospital, where they remain under treatment.

tions at the Kirti Nagar police station. The SUV driver was arrested, identified as Navleen Kaur, and the vehicle has been impounded,” Gupta said.

The CCTV footage also shows the driver briefly opening the car door before remaining inside for several seconds. She then stepped out, went towards the injured man and appeared to check on him before returning to the vehicle.

The police have registered a case under Sections 281 and 125A of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Cycling for health



Cabinet Minister Ashish Sood joins sports enthusiasts during ‘Sundays on Cycle’ and Raahgiri Day in Connaught Place, New Delhi.

FROM PAGE 1

11 layers of barricades...

Warning banners fixed to the barricades cite Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) and caution against unauthorised gatherings and demonstrations, warning of legal action for violations.

DCP Sachin Sharma, speaking to *The Tribune*, said, “To maintain law and order, we have imposed Section 163 of the BNSS in New Delhi, although as per Supreme Court’s order Jantar Mantar’s protest site has been kept out of this restriction. But, to hold a protest there, one needs a permission, without which it will be considered illegal and action will be taken accordingly.”

SECURITY CORDON EXTENDS BEYOND PROTEST GROUND

The ground visit showed that the restrictions are not confined to the boundary of the protest site. Roads leading towards it from Ashoka Road, Kerala House, Sansad Marg, Janpath and the Imperial Hotel side have been brought within the security arrangement.

Delhi Police, CISF and RAF personnel were stationed at several points behind and between the barricades.

PROLONGED SEALING

The present arrangement follows the security escalation dur-

ing the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) agitation. On July 19, the Delhi Police imposed Section 163 across New Delhi district ahead of the proposed Parliament march and strengthened security around Jantar Mantar. The July 20 agitation witnessed confrontations between protesters and police at several locations in central Delhi. By July 25, the Jantar Mantar protest ground had been completely barricaded and sealed. Security was subsequently strengthened further. On July 30, reports said the police had started welding barricades together amid apprehension that protesters could attempt to remove them.

The latest protests have brought another round of prohibitory orders and heavy deployment.

DESIGNATED PROTEST SITE CAN'T BE FREELY REACHED

The Supreme Court, in its 2018 judgment on protests at Jantar Mantar, recognised the site as an area earmarked for demonstrations and directed the Delhi Police Commissioner to frame a mechanism for its regulated use, while balancing the right to protest with public order and the rights of residents and offices.

The present ground situation highlights a striking distinction between designation and accessibility.

Man wanted in two forgery cases arrested

TRIBUNE NEWS SERVICE

NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 4

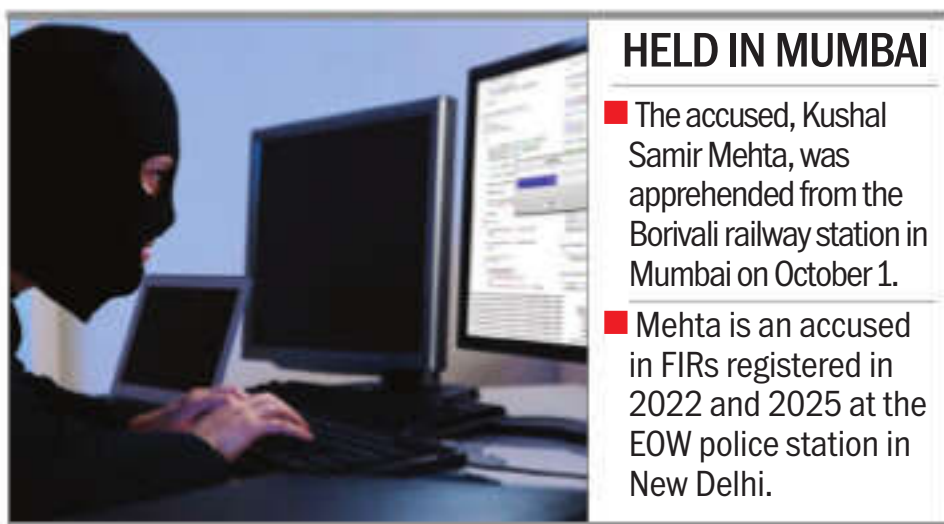
The Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of the Delhi Police has arrested a man wanted in two cases involving the alleged use of forged government documents after tracking his movements across Mumbai and Gujarat.

The accused, Kushal Samir Mehta, was apprehended from the Borivali railway station in Mumbai on October 1.

According to the police, Mehta is an accused in FIRs registered in 2022 and 2025 at the EOW police station in New Delhi. The first case was registered on a complaint by a Senior Accounts Officer of the Ministry of Finance regarding alleged attempts to encash government payments using forged sanction letters, treasury/payment instruments and other documents.

The questioned documents involved payments of Rs 7.62 crore in favour of M/s Andy’s Creation and Rs 11 crore in favour of M/s Essenzia Nutrition Pvt Ltd. Verification found the documents to be fake and the payments were not released, the police said.

During investigation, the police also found material relating to purported gov-



HELD IN MUMBAI

- The accused, Kushal Samir Mehta, was apprehended from the Borivali railway station in Mumbai on October 1.
- Mehta is an accused in FIRs registered in 2022 and 2025 at the EOW police station in New Delhi.

ernment and defence supply orders allegedly used to project genuine government contracts before beneficiary companies, banks and private financiers. The police said persons associated with the beneficiary concerns had disclosed Mehta’s alleged role in providing or arranging the questioned documents and financial instruments.

In another case, registered in September 2025 on a complaint by an Ahmedabad-based businessman, Mehta allegedly claimed to have access to government departments and promised to facilitate government-related work, recover business-related amounts and get official processes completed. The complainant alleged that he was induced to make payments on several occasions and suffered a loss of around Rs 3.12 crore.

The complainant also alleged receiving purported documents of several government departments and agencies, besides court-related documents, treasury cheques, demand drafts and receipts.

The police said Mehta had failed to join the investigation in the 2022 case despite repeated notices and court opportunities, following which non-bailable warrants were issued against him.

A team comprising SI Rahul, SI Ravinder Saroha and two head constables was formed to trace him. Technical surveillance indicated his presence in Mumbai on September 28. The team conducted verification in Ghatkopar but found that he was frequently changing locations.

Further analysis of call detail records and location charts indicated that Mehta moved from Mumbai

towards Gujarat on September 29, with his movements traced through Palitana, Bhavnagar, Ahmedabad and Vadodara.

The police said he subsequently returned to Mumbai by train. With assistance from the Railway Protection Force, the EOW team identified him in a reserved compartment of Train No. 12928 and apprehended him at the Borivali railway station during the early hours of October 1.

Mehta was produced before a Mumbai court for transit remand and subsequently brought to Delhi. The Patiala House Courts sent him to four-day police custody till October 7 for further interrogation, confrontation and recovery of documentary and electronic evidence.

The police said Mehta had also been found involved or named in two other forgery-related cases registered in Mumbai. His role in those cases and possible involvement in other offences were being verified.

The EOW is further investigating the alleged source and preparation of the forged documents, electronic and money trails and the involvement of other associates, beneficiaries and possible victims.

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The Tribune
Voice of the People

Society residents hold protest over security, basic amenities

SANJAY YADAV

GURUGRAM, OCTOBER 4 Residents of The Westerlies, Sector 108, Gurugram, held a peaceful demonstration on Sunday against Experion Developers Pvt Ltd and its maintenance agency Mainage Facility Management Pvt Ltd over security, sewage infrastructure, parks, power backup and maintenance services in the township.

According to The Westerlies Resident Welfare Association (RWA), the township's perimeter fencing and boundary walls are damaged at several points, while boom barriers and Park+RFID tags at the entry gates are not functioning effectively. The absence of the MyGate visitor-management system at Kite Gate has also raised concerns over visitor verification.

Residents have also raised concerns over the capacity of the sewage infrastructure. With approximately 900 plots in the township, the association has termed the existing trunk sewage line inadequate and has called for an independent technical audit and necessary augmentation of the network.

Residents have further objected to the increase in



Residents of The Westerlies hold a peaceful demonstration over security and basic amenities on Sunday.

CAM charges from Rs 10 to Rs 19 per sq yd per month over two years, representing an increase of approximately 90 per cent. The association has sought disclosure of the basis for the increase and audited accounts, and has demanded that CAM charges be rolled back to the last undisputed rate pending adjudication by HRERA.

The residents have also sought improvements in the development and maintenance of parks and green areas, operationalisation of the community club, reliable power backup, internal roads and drainage, as well as greater transparency in maintenance expenditure, including accounts and vendor details. The association has also sought the han-

dover of the religious site and all common areas and facilities.

The association has called upon Experion and Mainage to submit a written, time-bound action plan within 15 days. It reiterated that the demonstration was peaceful and disciplined. In the absence of concrete action, residents have stated that they will pursue further remedies before HRERA, GMDA, the district administration and other competent authorities.

RWA President Rajesh Joon stated, "Why are the amenities incomplete when the builder is charging more than necessary?" Citing irregularities on part of the builder, he recommended an SIT investigation and strict

legal action by the Haryana government.

RWA Vice President Ravinder Kumar Yadav stated, "All promises made by the builder remain unfulfilled, residents are deprived of basic amenities." He warned that the RWA would initiate legal action against the builder.

A resident Savita said all residents feel cheated. She expressed dismay over the failure to construct the community club and the fact that the builder sold off the place of worship.

Despite several attempts, officials of Experion Developers Pvt Ltd and its maintenance agency Mainage Facility Management Pvt Ltd could not be contacted.

Car damaged as rly underpass barrier falls in G'gram, none hurt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM, SEPTEMBER 4 The front section and bonnet of a car were badly damaged after an iron height barrier fell onto the car passing through a railway underpass in the Garhi-Harsaru area on Sunday morning.

Fortunately, the car driver, a private school administrator, escaped unharmed, while his wife had stepped out of the car moments before the mishap.

According to the school administrator Shyamvir Singh, he was returning to

school that morning after dropping off his wife. As his car was passing through the Garhi Harsaru railway underpass, the overhead iron height barrier suddenly collapsed onto the front of the car. Alarmed by the loud crash, nearby people rushed to the scene and assisted him. Although Shyamveer was shaken by the incident, he did not sustain any serious injuries.

After receiving information, a Government Railway Police (GRP) team arrived at the scene and assessed the situation. The

GRP inspected the damage to the car, and the affected party was assured that the contractor will bear the repair costs.

Following the accident, local residents demanded an inspection of the safety arrangements regarding the height barrier installed at the underpass. They point out that a large number of vehicles and pedestrians use this route daily, therefore, it was essential to verify the structural integrity and safety standards of the height barrier to prevent such incidents in future.

Offered 'tributes', influencer Kataria says 'I am alive'

SANJAY YADAV

GURUGRAM, OCTOBER 4 A claim regarding the death of social media influencer Bobby Kataria was made via his official Instagram account in Gurugram. As soon as the post surfaced, fans began paying tributes on social media, flooding the comments section with "Rest in Peace (RIP) Kataria Bhai" messages.

Later, Kataria himself refuted the claim by releasing a video from a new social media account and stated, "I am alive, folks; do not pay attention to the rumors. Someone hacked the account and posted false information."

Bobby Kataria stated that the old Instagram account used to make the false post was managed by someone else and had been hacked. Hackers carried out this act to create an atmosphere of confusion and fear among fans.

Hackers posted 12 consecutive videos from an old account, claiming that Bobby Kataria had passed away. These posts featured gym photos and old videos overlaid with text such as "Miss You Bhai" and "RIP." One of the gym-related posts has garnered over 2.3 million views. The account has around 32,700 followers.

A total of 214 posts have been made so far from the Instagram ID used to share this post.

Gurugram cops nab 10 for bringing waste from Delhi

SANJAY YADAV

GURUGRAM, OCTOBER 4 Following a recent direction from Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, the Gurugram police arrested 10 persons for illegally bringing garbage and plastic waste from Delhi to Gurugram.

Four separate cases were registered against the accused, and seven vehicles allegedly used in the offences have been recovered.

On Monday, CM Saini directed the police to impound vehicles bringing garbage from Delhi, stating that Gurugram will not be allowed to become Delhi's dumping ground.

The Gurugram Police are conducting a special campaign against persons involved in illegally bringing and dumping garbage/waste and plastic waste from Delhi into Gurugram, along with other related illegal activities. As part of this campaign, the Gurugram Police took action at various locations and arrested 10 accused.

As many as two cases were registered at the Bajghera police station, 1 at Udyog Vihar police station and 1 at the Rajendra Park police station in this regard. A total of seven vehicles, including canters and tractor-trolleys, used

in the offences were recovered from their possession.

Police investigation has revealed that the accused were allegedly involved in transporting garbage/waste and plastic waste from Delhi to Gurugram for dumping. Police teams intercepted such vehicles during checking.

Preliminary interrogation and investigation revealed that the accused were allegedly bringing garbage/waste and plastic waste from Delhi to Gurugram through a network connected with Delhi. The plastic was separated from the garbage/waste brought to Gurugram and segregated before being sent to other places. The police are conducting a detailed investigation into the entire network.

"Police teams are collecting information about the accused and the owners of the vehicles recovered for their alleged use in the offences. During the investigation, if the involvement or any role of any vehicle owner in such illegal activities is found, strict action will also be taken against the vehicle owners concerned as per law. We are conducting detailed interrogation of the accused and investigating the entire network related to the illegal activity," said a senior police officer.

Scattered, leaderless protests put over 5K cops to test

gathered, were stopped and detained, regrouped elsewhere and attempted to advance again. Despite repeated attempts, the groups did not turn into a single procession reaching Jantar Mantar. Police barricades remained in place around the designated protest area, with detainees transported to different police stations.

WOMEN'S SAFETY BECOMES SECOND FLASHPOINT

The policing itself has now become a separate issue. Three women journalists who were covering Saturday's protest complained of sexual harassment by police personnel. One complaint alleges that an ACP grabbed a woman journalist and pushed her while she was recording the detention of AISA president Neha Bora. The allegations have not been independently established.

AISA separately alleged that Bora was taken away on Sunday in a private vehicle without an official number plate and that no woman police officer was present inside the vehicle. The police had not immediately responded to those allegations.

Visuals also showed Bora attempting to cross a barricade as the police tried to stop her, while other women protesters were seen climbing over a vehicle amid the confrontation.

AAP Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj, detained on Sunday, alleged that police manhandled him and shared a photograph claiming he had been turned upside down during detention.

INDIA bloc parties to step...

affecting voters from minority communities and those living in poorer neighbourhoods.(The bloc constituents said they would organise district-level protests across Delhi on October 7 and 8. They will also join the march to the Election Commission headquarters on October 6, following a national call by INDIA bloc MPs.

The parties have announced a mass protest at the office of the Chief Electoral Officer at Kashmir Gate on November 7, ahead of the INDIA bloc's proposed national-level protest on November 1.

The parties also decided to coordinate their activities at the Delhi level and meet again on October 15 to plan further protests against the

FROM PAGE 1



Vehicles stuck in a traffic jam at the Ashok Road roundabout during a protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in New Delhi on Sunday. TRIBUNE PHOTO: MANAS RANJAN BHUI

SIR and demand the removal of the CEC.

The meeting was attended by leaders of the Congress, CPI(M), CPI, CPI(ML), RJD, RSP, AIFB and the TMC.

Youth Cong, NSUI workers take to streets, seek CEC's...

Meanwhile, the NSUI held a protest at the India Gate, demanding the resignation and arrest of Kumar. A large number of student activists participated in the demonstration and raised slogans seeking transparency and accountability in the electoral process.

NSUI national media in-charge Ravi Hanuman Pandey said the Election Commission was a constitutional institution responsible for protecting citizens' right to vote and that questions surrounding the electoral rolls required transparency and accountability.

The NSUI demanded an impartial investigation into the concerns it had raised over the electoral process and said students and young citizens would continue to raise the issue through democratic means.

Ridge gets legal shield as...

this legal protection will translate into protection on

the ground.

Notification can establish the legal status of land; it does not, by itself, remove existing encroachments or prevent future violations. Effective boundary demarcation, surveillance, action against illegal construction and protection against tree felling will determine whether the expansion becomes a meaningful conservation measure.

For Delhi, therefore, the latest figures mark both an environmental expansion and an enforcement challenge, turning thousands of hectares from legally vulnerable land into protected forest is only the first step. The harder task will be keeping them protected.

Plaint against Delhi ACP over 'molestation'...

She said around 6 pm, three women who identified themselves as journalists lodged complaints alleging manhandling by the Delhi Police officers and staff during their detention. "Their complaint has been registered, medical examinations have been conducted, and the matter has been referred to the Crime Branch," Yadav said, appealing to anyone possessing relevant footage to share it with the investigating agency.

The complaints have also drawn condemnation from journalist organisations and Opposition leaders, who have demanded action against the police personnel named in the allegations.

The police action came amid protests against the SIR and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. A gathering later assembled outside the Parliament Street police station in support of the complainants. Police officials asked the gathering to disperse, citing prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS, and warned that those refusing to leave could be detained.

Section 74 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita deals with assault or use of criminal force against a woman with intent to outrage her modesty and provides for imprisonment of one to five years.

EC row around Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls reignites a war of narratives

ADITI TANDON

THE bygone week saw the return of street protests to Delhi and Mumbai, political and financial nerve centres of India, as the row involving alleged irregularities in the working of the Election Commission of India escalated.

While the ruling BJP strategised in private on ways to manage the crisis, youth-led Cockroach Janta Party, Congress-led opposition INDIA bloc and Left-linked outfits hit the ground through separate agitations, culminating in the common demand of the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

Notwithstanding the massive citizen and opposition-

led offensives this time, the ruling dispensation, insiders say, is clear about one thing: There will be no going back on the stated position that the EC-led Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, at the heart of the controversy, is "key to national security and the purity of electoral roll."

The EC too, after reports suggested friction among election commissioners over nuances of SIR, described the exercise as a unanimous full commission decision later upheld by the Supreme Court and one that was about weeding out the deceased, duplicate and ineligible voters.

But critics of the regime and pro-democracy voices are determined to escalate matters this time.

The Congress-led INDIA

alliance is already drafting a parliamentary petition to remove the CEC, has sought the immediate cancellation of SIR, resignation of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and restoration of 13 crore people whom SIR struck off the rolls. The opposition has also vowed to build up a public campaign on the issue.

The BJP, for its part, upbeat after securing the critical resignation of education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, has said Gyanesh Kumar should go or the government should prepare for Jantar Mantar 2.0 on October 10.

For the first time on Sunday, a judge of the apex court, Ujjal Bhuyan, termed as intrinsically arbitrary any process that disenfranchises



millions of citizens.

As the challengers of Prime Minister Narendra Modi deploy new political idioms to transform the instant row into a mass political issue, the BJP, backed by NDA partners TDP, Shiv Sena, LJP and JDU, believes the crisis will blow over, as it has in the past.

To drive home their point,

saffron sources point to the past controversies such as the Rafale fighter jet deal, Pegasus spyware, Citizenship Amendment Act and Abrogation of Article 370 in J&K issues.

"In each of these issues, a political and legal challenge was mounted against the government. Everyone knows what happened," says a BJP leader, adding that the Congress habitually resorts to institution shaming every time the voters reject it.

A section of leaders in the Congress meanwhile feel while it's important to question the disenfranchisement of voters, as Rahul Gandhi is doing, more has to be done to make the opposition claims look credible.

"You lose the moral authority to question the EC and the poll process the moment you

accept the verdict where the Congress or the opposition parties win and denounce it where they lose. Maybe the Congress and wider opposition should consider boycotting the elections completely to mount real pressure on the voting systems," said a former veteran Congress leader.

This is precisely what the BJP is asking. Former education minister and BJP general secretary Smriti Irani was the first to question the Congress whether it would reject the mandates in Himachal Pradesh, Kerala, Telangana and states where the BJP was not in power and the opposition was.

Sangh Parivar's mouthpiece Organiser this week described attacks against the EC and agitations over student suicides as the latest

attempts by the "Communist-Islamist ecosystem" to discredit Indian institutions.

"Fueling protests, invoking caste sentiments, creating alienation towards the government and discrediting institutions is the new modus operandi of the Communist-Islamist cabal... Anti-Bharat forces from outside are funding these agitations and some opposition parties are falling prey to the game for short-term political ends," the Organiser editorial said on Saturday.

As the war of narratives explodes, it remains to be seen how far the Opposition and citizen-led movements are able to sustain the momentum against the EC.

This at a time when the BJP-RSS social media and grassroots outreach has begun circulating materi-

als suggesting that Gyanesh Kumar is being targeted for a reason.

"The government abrogated Article 370 and made Jammu and Kashmir an integral part of India. Who drafted the rules and bylaws for this process? Ram Janmabhoomi temple became a reality because of the PM Modi-led government. Who constituted Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust and framed its regulations? Which official prepared the government's stance on the Rafale controversy? The answer is Gyanesh Kumar," says one of the messages being amplified by right-wing handles to counter the BJP's and Opposition's anti-CEC campaign across online spaces..



Diljit Dosanjh's Aura India Tour to rock 7 cities

Diljit Dosanjh is set to take his music to more Indian cities with the Aura India Tour 2026, which will travel across the country in November and December. The India leg of the tour will begin in Delhi-NCR on November 1, followed by shows in Indore, Ahmedabad, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Lucknow. Chandigarh will also be part of the tour, with details of the show to be announced later.

Ahmedabad was earlier announced as the first Indian stop of the tour, with Dosanjh set to perform at the Narendra Modi Stadium on November 21. The tour will now cover seven cities over a period of six weeks. Dosanjh, who has built a strong fan base in India as well as overseas, said he was looking forward to performing in different cities across the country. Sharing his excitement, the singer-actor, as per a release, said, "Apne desh vich perform karan di vibe hi hor hundi aa. Iss tour de naal ik vaar phir Delhi ton Indore tak apne desh de shehraan vich apne fans de naal milan da mauka mil reha hai, te main is safar layi bahut excited haan. Tuhada pyaar hamesha mere naal reha hai, hun vaari aa tuhade shehar aavn di. November te December milde aan, poori vibe de naal!"

During the tour, Dosanjh is expected to perform some of his popular songs, including G.O.A.T., Ikki Kudi, Lalkara, Lover, 5 Taara, Case and Water. Dosanjh has performed at venues including Madison Square Garden and Wembley Stadium.—ANI

WHAT'S HOT

eat

ROLLED AND READY

A STALL in Sector 43's Western Court is turning heads with its loaded rolls, generously stuffed and dripping with mayo-rich filling. The special butter chicken roll is the standout, packing smoky, buttery chicken and fresh greens into every wrap. Messy, indulgent, and worth the napkins.



play

MUSIC & VERSE

CHANDIGARH hosts *Rangan Di Ustat*, an evening of Punjabi music and poetry featuring composer-performer Manpreet Singh, known for compositions like *Poshak* and *Mehman* (sung by Babu Maan). It's on October 10 at Tagore Theatre.



laugh

RELATABLE AND REAL

MADHAV MEHANDRU brings his stand-up show *Kalakaar* to North Studio Live, spinning everyday Punjabi life, family and overthinking into an evening of relatable stories and jokes. At North Studio Live on October 10.



Tribune Life Style

DELHI | MONDAY | 5 OCTOBER 2026



The leading lady

Yukti Thareja has signed on as the female lead for *Farzi* Season 2. "I am playing the main female lead. I am the only central female protagonist this season. My character is a fearless Gen-Z woman who speaks up against the system," she said.

As Akshay Kumar explores a darker side in *Haiwaan*, here's a look at the stars who left a lasting impression by playing antagonists

WE'RE used to seeing Bollywood's biggest stars as the hero—saving the day, winning hearts and taking on the bad guys. But every once in a while, they switch sides and step into darker roles, and that's when things get interesting. Over the years, some of Bollywood's biggest leading men have taken on villains and grey characters, giving audiences performances they still remember.

With Akshay Kumar now exploring a darker role in *Haiwaan*, here's a look at some of the stars who showed that being the bad guy can be just as memorable as being the hero.

AKSHAY KUMAR: *Haiwaan*

Akshay Kumar is taking that turn again with *Haiwaan*. The actor, who has moved comfortably between action, comedy and drama over the years, is playing a character that is far removed from his usual hero image. What makes the role interesting is that Akshay has described his character as outright dark, with no grey shades at all. It is a clear departure from the kind of leading-man roles audiences are used to seeing him in, making his turn in *Haiwaan* all the more interesting to watch.

SHAH RUKH KHAN: *Darr*

Shah Rukh Khan was already making his presence felt in the early 1990s when he played Rahul Mehra in *Darr*. Rahul is obsessed with Kiran and his love gradually turns into something far more disturbing. Taking on such a dark role so early in his career was a risk, especially when Khan was still establishing himself as a leading man. But his intense performance, along with the charm he was already known for, made Rahul one of the most memorable characters in the film. It also showed that Khan was willing to take chances rather than get stereotyped into one kind of hero.

AMITABH BACHCHAN: *Don*

Amitabh Bachchan's *Don* remains one of the most recognisable characters in Hindi cinema. The character was ruthless, confident and always seemed to be one step ahead. Bachchan gave him a cool, effortless quality that made *Don* more than just the villain of the story. It was the kind of role that suited his towering screen presence and eventually became a part of his legacy.

AJAY DEVGN: *Kaal*

Ajay Devgn took a different route with *Kaal* at a time when he was already a well-established leading man. After films like *Company*, *Gangajal* and *Yuva*, he had built a strong image around intense and serious hero roles. Playing Kali Pratap Singh gave him a chance to explore something much darker. Kali is mysterious, unpredictable and has an unsettling presence, and the performance stays quiet rather than overdoing it. His screen presence added a sense of mystery throughout the film and made the character one of the most memorable parts of *Kaal*.

SANJAY DUTT: *Khalnayak*

Sanjay Dutt was at the centre of *Khalnayak* as Ballu Balram, a criminal with a reputation that precedes him. The film gave Dutt the chance to play a character who was rough around the edges and firmly outside the conventional hero mould. His natural screen presence did much of the work, turning Ballu into one of the memorable characters of 1990s Hindi cinema.

Bollywood's good guys gone bad



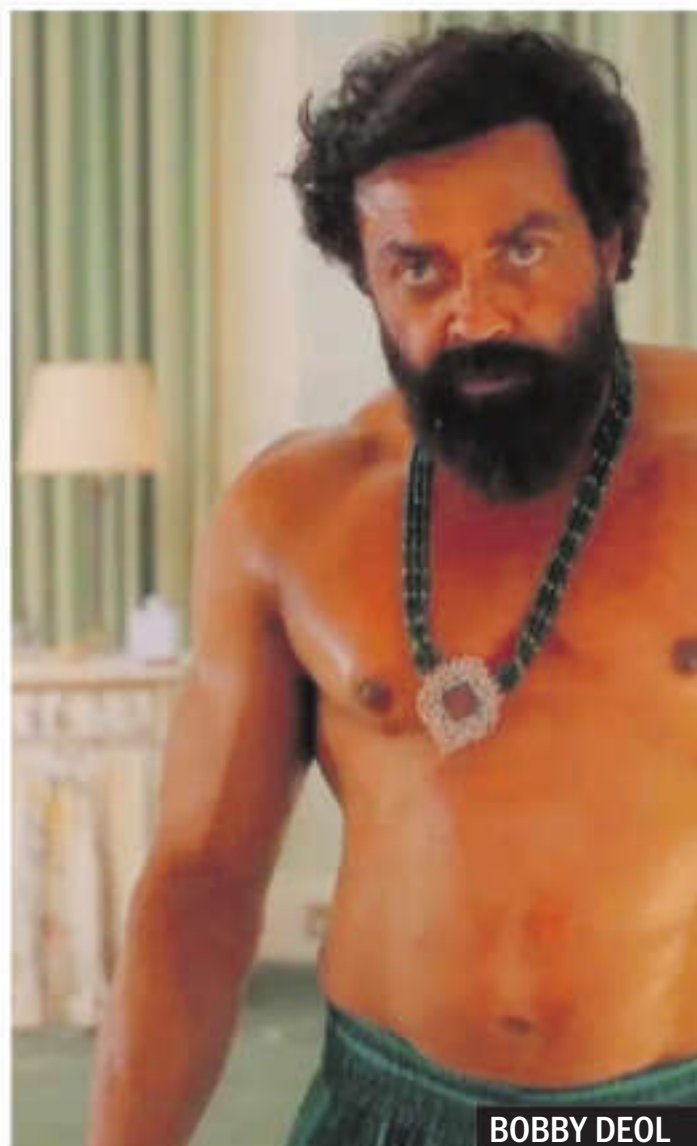
AKSHAY KUMAR



AMITABH BACHCHAN



AJAY DEVGN



BOBBY DEOL



SHAH RUKH KHAN



SANJAY DUTT

BOBBY DEOL: *Animal*

Bobby Deol's Abrar Haque became one of the most talked-about parts of *Animal*, despite having limited screen time. The character's quiet menace, intense expressions and imposing presence made him stand out without relying

on long dialogues. Deol also brought a sense of unpredictability to Abrar, making audiences curious about what he would do next. The role became a major talking point after the film's release and gave Deol one of the most memorable characters of his career.

These performances are very different from one another, but they have one thing in common: each star was willing to experiment and step outside the image audiences had come to expect. And sometimes, that change of direction is exactly what makes a character stick.

CHAT UP

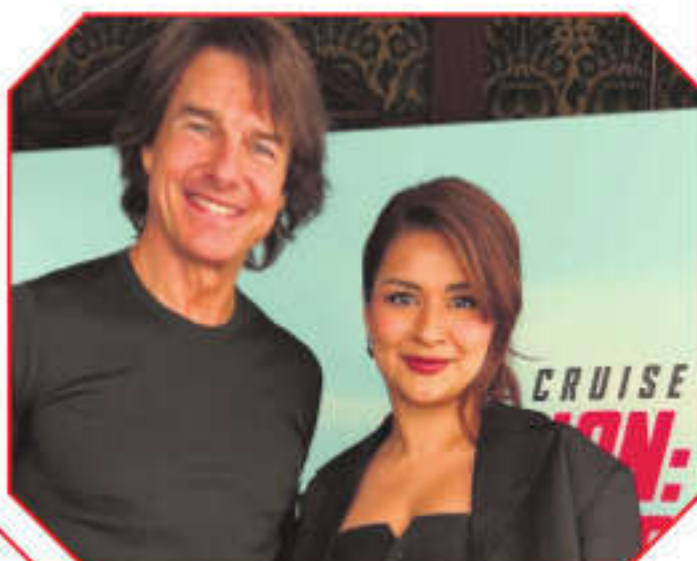
WEDDING BELLS

More than two months after tying the knot with actor Cody John, Emma Roberts has shared a closer look at their wedding day. The actor shared a post on her Instagram. In the photos, Roberts and John can be seen exchanging vows.



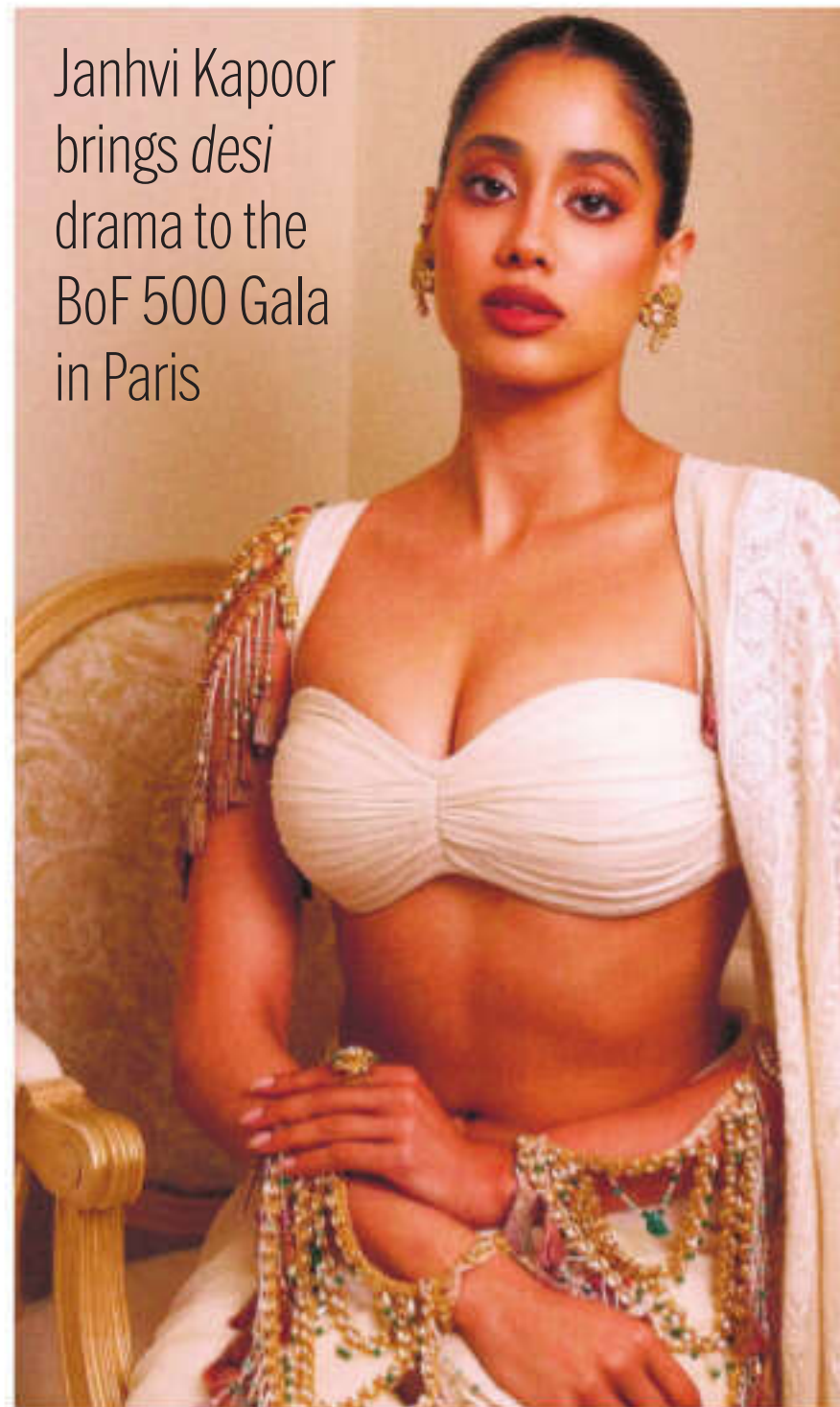
AVNEET MEETS CRUISE

Avneet Kaur crossed paths with Hollywood star Tom Cruise at the world premiere of his new film *Digger* in London on September 23. Much of their exchange centered on a standout scene from the film, a lengthy monologue shot without a single cut.



'USE IMAGES IN ORIGINAL FORM'

With the use of AI-generated and AI-edited images on the rise, Yami Gautam has urged the media to refrain from altering her photographs. On X, she wrote, "A sincere request to the media. Please refrain from using AI to alter or enhance my photographs from public appearances. Kindly use images in original form."



Janhvi Kapoor brings desi drama to the BoF 500 Gala in Paris

Diva's day out

Janhvi Kapoor brought Indian craftsmanship to the global fashion stage as she attended the BoF 500 Gala in Paris, dressed in a custom creation by Pankaj S Heritage, styled by Rhea Kapoor.

The ethereal off-white ensemble reimaged the classic six-yard silhouette with a contemporary, low-slung drape, bare shoulders and an elegant floor-skimming pallu.

Crafted from 460-count Bengal muslin, the look celebrated the beauty of Indian textiles while keeping its aesthetic distinctly modern. The understated ivory canvas was contrasted with elaborate handcrafted adornments featuring gold beads, pearls, shells, emeralds, polkis and tassels, creating a dramatic shoulder-to-arm jewellery moment. — TNS